

War as a Catalyst: How Russia's Full-Scale Invasion of Ukraine Transformed the Diplomatic, Security, and Economic Relations in Central and Eastern Europe

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Abstract

The full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022, represents a tectonic shift in the global geopolitical landscape, acting as a violent catalyst for the comprehensive restructuring of international relations within Central and Eastern Europe (CEE). This paper examines the multifaceted transformation of diplomatic, security, and economic paradigms across the region, exploring how frontline states have transitioned from peripheral actors to the strategic core of European defense. By analyzing the realignment of regional alliances, the revitalization of NATO's Eastern Flank, and the urgent decoupling from Russian energy dependencies, the study argues that the war has forged a new CEE identity rooted in shared existential security concerns and democratic resilience. Drawing upon the intellectual legacy of Alexis de Tocqueville, the research further evaluates the tension between sovereignty, collective security, and the preservation of democratic institutions under the pressure of prolonged conflict. The findings suggest that the emerging regional order in CEE is characterized by a "strategic avant-garde" role of states like Poland and the Baltics, which are redefining the continent's security posture and accelerating the integration of Ukraine into the Euro-Atlantic architecture, thereby fundamentally altering the European balance of power.

Introduction

The early hours of February 24, 2022, did more than shatter the peace on the European continent; they dismantled a decades-old illusion of "eternal stability" that had characterized Western strategic thinking since the end of the Cold War. For the nations of Central and Eastern Europe (CEE), the invasion of Ukraine was not merely a distant geopolitical event but a visceral

confirmation of historical anxieties and long-ignored warnings. This moment marked the definitive end of the post-Cold War settlement—a period often defined by the "End of History" optimism—and initiated a violent transition toward a fragmented, yet more assertive, regional order.

Central and Eastern Europe, a region historically caught in the gravitational pull of competing empires, has emerged from the shadow of this conflict as the new center of gravity for European security. The war has acted as a catalyst, accelerating processes that were previously stagnant and exposing fault lines that had been papered over by economic pragmatism. States such as Poland, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania have moved from being "security consumers" to "security providers," fundamentally challenging the traditional dominance of the Franco-German engine in shaping EU and NATO policies toward the East.

The primary objective of this research is to analyze the depth and permanence of these transformations. The central research question asks: To what extent has Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine restructured the diplomatic, security, and economic relations of CEE states, and what are the characteristics of the emerging regional order? To answer this, the study adopts a multidisciplinary approach, blending neo-realist perspectives on power dynamics with constructivist analyses of regional identity and sovereignty.

Furthermore, this analysis finds a profound resonance in the political philosophy of Alexis de Tocqueville. Though his seminal work focused on the burgeoning democracy of the United States, Tocqueville's insights into the fragility of democratic institutions, the "tyranny of the majority," and the necessity of civic engagement are startlingly relevant to contemporary Ukraine and its neighbors. In the face of autocratic aggression, the states of CEE have demonstrated a "Tocquevillian" resilience—where the defense of national sovereignty is inextricably linked to the survival of democratic liberty. The war has forced a re-evaluation of how democracy functions under the shadow of total war, and whether the collective security mechanisms of the West are capable of protecting the "local self-government" and individual freedoms that Tocqueville so highly prized.

The paper is structured into six comprehensive sections. The first section contextualizes the pre-war order, examining the contradictions of the European security architecture prior to 2022. The second section details the diplomatic realignment within the region, highlighting the shifting roles of major CEE actors. The third section explores the radical reimaging of NATO's Eastern Flank and the military revolution currently unfolding in the region. The fourth section addresses the economic dimensions, specifically the decoupling from Russian energy and the integration of the Ukrainian economy into the European market. The fifth section

evaluates the rise of new regional alliances, such as the Lublin Triangle and the Three Seas Initiative, and the crisis within traditional formats like the Visegrad Group. Finally, the sixth section applies a Tocquevillian lens to the democratic dimension of the conflict, assessing how the war has reshaped the concepts of freedom and sovereignty in the 21st century.

As we stand at this historical crossroads, the experience of Ukraine and its neighbors serves as a laboratory for the future of international relations. The restructuring of Central and Eastern Europe is not merely a regional phenomenon but a precursor to a new global arrangement where the defense of democratic values is once again the primary driver of strategic alignment.

Chapter 1. Central and Eastern Europe

Before February 2022: The Pre-War Order

1.1 Defining Central and Eastern Europe

Central and Eastern Europe is a region that defies simple cartographic definition. Its boundaries shift depending on the analytical framework employed—geographic, cultural, political, or historical—and the very act of defining it carries profound geopolitical implications. For the purposes of this study, CEE encompasses the countries designated by Blue Europe's operational definition: Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Belarus, Poland, Ukraine, Russia, Moldova, the Czech Republic, Slovakia, Hungary, Romania, Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Serbia, Montenegro, Kosovo, North Macedonia, Albania, Bulgaria, and Georgia. This is a vast and internally diverse space, stretching from the Baltic Sea to the Black Sea and from the Adriatic coast to the Caucasus Mountains, encompassing populations with radically different historical trajectories, linguistic families, and geopolitical orientations.

The conceptual ambiguity of "Central and Eastern Europe" is itself historically significant. During the Cold War, the region was subsumed under the monolithic label of the "Eastern Bloc," obscuring the profound differences between a Poland fiercely resistant to Soviet cultural penetration and a Bulgaria considerably more integrated into the Soviet system. After 1989, the triumphant narrative of Western liberal democracy projected a superficial unity onto a region that was, in fact, navigating multiple and often contradictory transitions simultaneously: from planned to market economies, from single-party systems to multiparty democracies, and from Soviet-dominated foreign policies to the complex pursuit of Euro-Atlantic integration.

This internal diversity has never been more consequential than in the period leading up to February 2022. The region was not a monolith but a constellation of different strategic cultures, security perceptions, and economic dependencies. The Baltic states viewed Russia as an existential threat and had been arguing as much within NATO for nearly two decades. Poland occupied an intermediate position, deeply concerned about Russian aggression but also engaged in complex domestic political struggles that colored its foreign policy. Hungary and Slovakia, by contrast, had drifted toward what some analysts described as "illiberal" governance models, cultivating far warmer relationships with Moscow than their alliance commitments might have suggested. Romania and Bulgaria, geographically proximate to the Black Sea theater, were attentive to Russian naval ambitions but less vociferous in their warnings. The Western Balkans remained mired in the protracted process of EU and NATO

accession, their attention divided between internal political disputes and the slow bureaucratic machinery of European integration.

Understanding this internal differentiation is essential for any serious analysis of the post-2022 transformation. The war did not act upon a homogeneous regional entity; it acted upon a fractured, contested, and internally divided space, and the nature of its impact was therefore refracted through the particular historical experiences and strategic cultures of each individual state.

1.2 The Post-Cold War Settlement and Its Contradictions

The collapse of the Soviet Union and the subsequent enlargement of NATO and the European Union represented, for the majority of CEE states, the realization of a long-deferred historical aspiration. The accession of Poland, Hungary, the Czech Republic, and the Baltic states into NATO between 1999 and 2004, followed by their integration into the European Union, appeared to resolve the fundamental question of regional security that had haunted Central and Eastern Europe for centuries. The "return to Europe" was not merely a political project; it was a civilizational statement, a declaration that these nations belonged within the community of liberal democratic states and would be protected by the collective security guarantees that such membership entailed.

Yet the post-Cold War settlement was built on a series of assumptions that proved, over time, to be profoundly fragile. The first and most consequential of these was the belief that economic interdependence between Western Europe and Russia would function as a pacifying force—that trade and investment ties would gradually moderate Russian behavior and integrate Moscow into a rules-based international order. This conviction, most forcefully articulated by successive German governments under the framework of *Wandel durch Handel* (change through trade), drove the construction of the Nord Stream pipeline system, which carried Russian natural gas directly to Germany beneath the Baltic Sea, deliberately bypassing the transit territories of Ukraine and Poland. For the states of Eastern Europe, this was not merely a commercial transaction but a security liability of the first order—a infrastructure that simultaneously enriched Moscow and reduced the strategic costs of potential aggression against transit states.

The second structural contradiction of the post-Cold War order was the persistent gap between the formal security guarantees provided by NATO membership and the actual military posture of the Alliance in its eastern territories. For much of the post-Cold War period, NATO's presence in CEE was largely symbolic. The "three no's" reassurances given to Russia in the

1990s—no permanent substantial combat forces, no nuclear weapons, no infrastructure changes—reflected a Western strategic culture that still conceptualized Russian aggression as a remote contingency rather than an operational planning assumption. The Alliance's Enhanced Forward Presence, established after Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014, deployed multinational battle groups to Poland and the three Baltic states, but these forces were explicitly characterized as a "tripwire" rather than a genuine deterrent—sufficient to trigger Article 5 but insufficient to repel a major conventional assault.

The third contradiction was perhaps the most insidious: the willingness of key Western European states, particularly France and Germany, to treat the security concerns of CEE as secondary to the imperatives of managing the relationship with Moscow. The repeated assurances from Berlin and Paris that the Nord Stream pipelines were "purely commercial" projects, the reluctance to move more rapidly on Ukrainian and Georgian NATO membership following the 2008 Bucharest Summit, and the persistent advocacy for dialogue and de-escalation in the face of Russian aggression all contributed to a growing sense of alienation among the states of the region. Estonian, Lithuanian, and Polish warnings about Russian intentions were politely received and quietly disregarded. The strategic culture of "old Europe," shaped by the experience of 20th-century wars fought on Western European soil, consistently underestimated the threat posed by a revisionist Russia to the nations that had lived within its sphere of influence.

1.3 Ukraine's Position Before 2022

Ukraine's pre-war position within the regional order was defined by a structural tension between its geopolitical aspirations and its domestic vulnerabilities. The 2004 Orange Revolution and, more decisively, the 2013–2014 Euromaidan revolution demonstrated the profound strength of Ukrainian civil society's democratic aspirations and its desire for integration into the Euro-Atlantic community. The Association Agreement with the European Union, which entered into force in 2017, represented the most tangible institutional expression of this orientation, establishing deep and comprehensive free trade provisions and aligning Ukrainian regulatory frameworks with European standards.

Yet Ukraine's path toward Euro-Atlantic integration was complicated by a series of factors that its adversaries consistently exploited. The Minsk Agreements of 2014 and 2015, negotiated in the aftermath of Russia's initial intervention in the Donbas and the annexation of Crimea, created a frozen conflict that served Moscow's interests far more than Kyiv's. The agreements effectively recognized a Russian sphere of influence within Ukrainian territory,

demanded constitutional changes that would have given Russian-backed separatist entities a veto over Ukrainian foreign policy, and generated a diplomatic framework in which France and Germany acted as brokers rather than advocates for Ukrainian sovereignty. For Ukraine, the Minsk process was a strategic trap—an arrangement that precluded military resolution of the conflict while simultaneously blocking the political and institutional changes necessary for NATO membership.

The question of NATO membership itself was a source of considerable strategic ambiguity. The 2008 Bucharest Summit communiqué famously declared that Ukraine and Georgia "will become members of NATO," but declined to offer either country a Membership Action Plan, effectively leaving them in a geopolitical no-man's land. This decision, driven primarily by German and French opposition, sent a deeply problematic signal to Moscow: that the two countries were neither firmly within the Western security umbrella nor definitively excluded from the possibility of membership. It was, in effect, an invitation to continued Russian pressure and interference.

Domestically, Ukraine struggled with the legacies of post-Soviet state formation: endemic corruption, oligarchic capture of key economic and political institutions, and the challenge of building a coherent national identity in a society that Russian propaganda persistently characterized as artificially divided between "Russian-speaking East" and "Ukrainian-speaking West." The election of Volodymyr Zelensky in 2019, running on a platform of anti-corruption and peace negotiations, initially raised hopes for a breakthrough in the Donbas conflict, but the structural dynamics of Russian policy made genuine compromise impossible on terms compatible with Ukrainian sovereignty.

1.4 Warning Signs: 2021 and the Road to War

The year 2021 represented the final chapter of the pre-war order, a period in which the evidence of Russian intent became increasingly unmistakable while the Western response remained largely constrained by the habits and assumptions of the preceding decades. In the spring of 2021, Russia conducted a large-scale military buildup along Ukraine's borders and in occupied Crimea, deploying approximately 100,000 troops in what was officially characterized as a military exercise. The buildup was subsequently partially reversed, but it served as a deliberate demonstration of capability and will—a signal to both Ukraine and its Western partners of the costs that resistance would entail.

In July 2021, Vladimir Putin published a lengthy essay titled "On the Historical Unity of Russians and Ukrainians," in which he articulated with unusual clarity his denial of

Ukrainian statehood and national identity. The essay, which described Ukrainians and Russians as "one people" and characterized Ukrainian sovereignty as an artificial construction of Soviet nationalities policy, provided an ideological framework for what would follow. For analysts attentive to the text, it was a declaration of intent barely disguised as historical reflection.

The autumn and winter of 2021 saw a second, far larger military buildup along Ukraine's northern, eastern, and southern borders. By December 2021, Russia had deployed an estimated 175,000 troops and was publicly demanding legally binding guarantees from NATO that the Alliance would cease its eastward expansion and withdraw forces from all member states that had joined after 1997—a demand that was diplomatically inconceivable and appeared designed to be rejected. The intelligence services of the United States and the United Kingdom, sharing unusually specific assessments with allies and the public, warned explicitly that Russia was planning a full-scale invasion. Many European governments, conditioned by years of managing Russian "hybrid" threats and frozen conflicts, found the prospect of a conventional assault difficult to credit.

The divergence in threat perception between Eastern and Western Europe was striking. In Tallinn, Riga, Vilnius, and Warsaw, the military buildup was regarded with the grim recognition of nations that had spent decades warning of precisely this eventuality. In Berlin, Paris, and Rome, there remained a persistent instinct to seek diplomatic accommodation, to find a formula that would preserve the economic relationship with Moscow while offering rhetorical solidarity to Kyiv. This divergence was not merely a difference of opinion; it reflected fundamentally different historical experiences of Russian power and fundamentally different assessments of what was ultimately at stake.

When Russian forces crossed into Ukrainian territory in the early hours of February 24, 2022, the post-Cold War order did not merely crack—it collapsed. The assumptions that had governed European security for three decades, the belief in the pacifying power of economic interdependence, the adequacy of symbolic military deterrence, and the possibility of a stable *modus vivendi* with a revisionist Russia, were simultaneously falsified. For Central and Eastern Europe, the invasion was the terrible confirmation of what had been known and feared for years. For Western Europe and the broader international community, it was a forced and painful awakening—the beginning of a process of strategic recalibration that, as the subsequent sections of this study will demonstrate, continues to reshape the architecture of the entire continent.

Chapter 2. Diplomatic Realignment in Central and Eastern Europe After the Invasion

2.1 The First 72 Hours: Immediate Diplomatic Responses

The diplomatic response to Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine unfolded with a speed and intensity that surprised even seasoned observers of European politics. Within hours of the first missile strikes on Ukrainian cities, the institutional machinery of NATO, the European Union, and the United Nations was set in motion, producing emergency sessions, extraordinary summits, and a cascade of declarations that collectively signaled a fundamental rupture in the continent's post-Cold War diplomatic architecture.

NATO's North Atlantic Council convened in emergency session on the morning of February 24, invoking Article 4 of the Washington Treaty—the consultation mechanism that falls short of the collective defense guarantee of Article 5 but signals a serious threat to the security of one or more Alliance members. The meeting, attended by ambassadors rather than heads of state, produced a condemnation of Russian aggression and a commitment to reinforce the Alliance's Eastern Flank. Within days, NATO activated its Response Force for the first time in the Alliance's history for collective defense purposes, deploying elements to member states bordering Ukraine and Russia.

The European Union's response was, by the standards of that institution's notoriously deliberate decision-making processes, remarkably swift. The European Council convened an emergency summit on the evening of February 24, at which leaders agreed in principle to impose unprecedented sanctions on Russia and to provide financial and material support to Ukraine. The decision to supply lethal weapons to Ukraine through the European Peace Facility—a mechanism never previously used to fund arms transfers to a country at war—represented a historic departure from the EU's traditional self-conception as a "civilian power."

At the United Nations, the Security Council convened an emergency session at Ukraine's request, where Russia exercised its veto to block a resolution condemning the invasion. The General Assembly subsequently adopted Resolution ES-11/1 on March 2, demanding Russia's immediate withdrawal from Ukrainian territory. The vote—141 in favor, 5 against, 35 abstentions—provided a measure of the international community's response, though the significant bloc of abstentions, including China, India, and most of the Global South, foreshadowed the more complex diplomatic battles that would unfold over the following months.

For the states of Central and Eastern Europe, the first 72 hours were a period of grim validation. The invasion confirmed what their governments had been arguing for years, and it immediately placed them at the center of a transformed diplomatic landscape. Their experience, their geographic proximity, and their historical understanding of Russian imperial behavior made them indispensable interlocutors—not only for Ukraine but for the broader Western alliance seeking to formulate a coherent and effective response.

2.2 Poland: From Regional Power to Frontline State

No country in Central and Eastern Europe underwent a more dramatic diplomatic transformation as a result of the invasion than Poland. In the years preceding February 2022, Poland's international standing had been significantly complicated by its ruling Law and Justice party's conflicts with the European Union over judicial independence and the rule of law. Warsaw found itself simultaneously arguing for a harder line against Russia and defending domestic policies that the European Commission characterized as incompatible with EU democratic standards. This contradiction had limited Poland's effectiveness as a diplomatic actor, reducing its credibility in Brussels precisely when its security arguments were most urgently needed.

The invasion resolved this contradiction by elevating the security dimension of European politics above all others. Almost overnight, Poland's geographic position on NATO's eastern frontier, its substantial military capability, and its intimate knowledge of Russian strategic behavior made it the indispensable partner that it had long sought to be recognized as. Warsaw became the primary logistical hub for Western military assistance to Ukraine, with the vast majority of weapons, ammunition, and humanitarian supplies transiting through Polish territory. Polish airports and rail networks handled an extraordinary volume of military equipment, while the Polish state organized the reception and integration of what would become the largest refugee population in European history—over three million Ukrainians found refuge in Poland in the months following the invasion.

Diplomatically, Poland seized the initiative with remarkable energy. Polish Prime Minister Mateusz Morawiecki and Presidents of Poland, Czech Republic and Slovenia were among the first Western leaders to visit Kyiv following the invasion, traveling by train to meet President Zelensky in March 2022—a gesture of solidarity that carried enormous symbolic weight at a moment when the Ukrainian capital remained under direct military threat. Poland consistently advocated for the strongest possible sanctions against Russia, the fastest possible

military assistance to Ukraine, and the clearest possible pathway toward Ukrainian NATO membership.

The transformation extended to Poland's bilateral relationships within the region. The historical tensions between Warsaw and Kyiv—rooted in the complex and often tragic shared history of the two nations, including the massacres of the Volhynia region during the Second World War—were substantially, though not entirely, subordinated to the imperatives of the present crisis. Poland's government and civil society mobilized with remarkable solidarity, and the practical experience of hosting millions of Ukrainian refugees accelerated a process of cultural and human integration that no diplomatic initiative could have achieved in comparable time.

Poland also used the crisis to advance its long-standing argument for a fundamental rebalancing of power within NATO and the European Union, pushing for greater decision-making influence for states on the Alliance's eastern frontier and challenging the traditional primacy of the Franco-German axis in shaping European strategic culture. This was not merely a matter of institutional politics; it reflected a genuine conviction, shared across the Polish political spectrum, that the security architecture of Europe could no longer be designed primarily in Paris and Berlin by governments whose historical experience of Russian power was fundamentally different from that of nations living on the Alliance's exposed eastern edge.

2.3 The Baltic States: Vindication and Vulnerability

For Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania, the Russian invasion of Ukraine was the simultaneous experience of vindication and intensified vulnerability. For nearly two decades, the governments and security establishments of the three Baltic states had been warning their NATO allies that Russia's revisionist ambitions extended far beyond its immediate neighborhood and that the Alliance's posture in the region was dangerously inadequate. These warnings had been received with varying degrees of attention and, frequently, a condescension born of the assumption that small states on Europe's northeastern periphery were prone to historical anxieties that distorted their strategic judgment.

The invasion demolished these condescensions with brutal finality. The Baltic states' intelligence assessments, their threat perceptions, and their policy recommendations—for higher defense spending, permanent Allied forces on their territory, and a clear membership pathway for Ukraine—were retrospectively vindicated in the most unambiguous possible terms. This vindication carried immediate diplomatic consequences. The credibility of the Baltic governments within NATO councils increased dramatically, and their policy preferences—

previously treated as the understandable but ultimately exaggerated concerns of small frontline states—were suddenly recognized as prescient strategic analysis.

Estonia distinguished itself through the quality and consistency of its diplomatic advocacy. Tallinn consistently called for the provision of heavy weapons to Ukraine at a time when many Western governments were still debating the wisdom of such transfers, and Estonian President Alar Karis and Prime Minister Kaja Kallas emerged as among the most articulate and influential voices arguing for a comprehensive Western response. Kallas, in particular, became a major figure in European diplomatic discourse, ultimately appointed as the European Union’s High Representative for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy in 2024—a remarkable elevation that reflected both her personal capabilities and the new strategic weight of the Baltic region within EU deliberations.

Latvia and Lithuania pursued parallel tracks, coordinating closely with Estonia and with Poland in advocating for the strongest possible Western response. The three Baltic states were among the first to provide military assistance to Ukraine, drawing on their own defense stockpiles despite their limited scale. Lithuania’s decision in June 2022 to restrict the transit of certain goods to the Russian exclave of Kaliningrad—citing EU sanctions regulations—demonstrated a willingness to accept significant bilateral risks in defense of the broader sanctions framework, generating considerable Russian pressure but also considerable Allied support.

The vulnerability dimension of the Baltic experience was equally significant. The three states share land borders with Russia and Belarus, and their geographic situation—particularly the exposed Suwalki Gap connecting Poland to Lithuania, which represents NATO’s only land link to the Baltic states—made them acutely conscious of their own potential exposure to Russian pressure or aggression. The invasion of Ukraine concentrated Baltic strategic thinking on the question of whether NATO’s reinforced posture was genuinely sufficient to deter Russian aggression against Alliance members and, if deterrence failed, whether the Alliance had the capacity to defend Baltic territory against a serious Russian assault. These concerns drove the Baltic states’ continued advocacy for increased Allied troop deployments, pre-positioned equipment, and the upgrade of Enhanced Forward Presence battle groups to brigade-level formations capable of genuine territorial defense rather than merely symbolic presence.

2.4 Hungary and Slovakia: Dissenting Voices Within CEE

The near-unanimity of Central and Eastern Europe's diplomatic response to the invasion was complicated by the positions of Hungary and, from 2023, Slovakia—two states whose governments chose to define their national interests in terms fundamentally different from those of their regional neighbors. These dissenting positions were not merely diplomatic inconveniences; they revealed deep structural tensions within the CEE region and raised serious questions about the coherence and durability of the emerging regional consensus.

Hungary's Prime Minister Viktor Orbán had cultivated unusually close ties with Vladimir Putin over the preceding decade, pursuing energy agreements, accepting Russian financing for the expansion of the Paks nuclear power plant, and systematically blocking or weakening EU measures that Budapest characterized as unduly provocative toward Moscow. These relationships survived the invasion intact—or nearly so. While Hungary formally endorsed the EU sanctions packages and NATO's collective response to the invasion, it consistently sought exemptions for Hungarian energy imports from Russian sanctions, blocked or delayed military assistance packages routed through EU mechanisms, and refused to permit the transit of weapons to Ukraine across Hungarian territory. Orbán's public statements characterized the war as a conflict in which Hungary had no stake and peace as achievable through negotiation on terms that implicitly accepted Russian territorial gains—a position that aligned him more closely with Moscow's preferred narrative than with the overwhelming consensus of his EU and NATO partners.

The Hungarian position generated intense frustration within the region and within the Alliance. For Poland and the Baltic states in particular, Budapest's stance was not merely an inconvenient dissent but a potential security liability—an indication that the consensus mechanisms of NATO and the EU could be weaponized by a member state with close ties to the adversary to obstruct collective action. The recurring spectacle of Hungary blocking or delaying EU decisions on Ukraine assistance, only to ultimately acquiesce under political pressure in exchange for concessions on unrelated issues, became a recurring source of tension in European councils.

Slovakia's trajectory was more complex and more dynamic. Under the government of Eduard Heger, Slovakia had been among the more forthcoming CEE states in providing military assistance to Ukraine, including the transfer of its MiG-29 fighter aircraft—among the first such transfers of combat aircraft by any NATO member. However, the parliamentary elections of September 2023 returned Robert Fico's SMER party to power, initiating a fundamental reorientation of Slovak foreign policy. Fico, whose rhetoric mirrored many of

Orbán's positions on the war, moved to halt Slovak government arms transfers to Ukraine and characterized the conflict in terms sympathetic to Russian narratives. The attempted assassination of Fico in May 2024, which left the prime minister seriously wounded, temporarily disrupted Slovak governance but ultimately did not fundamentally alter the country's diplomatic trajectory.

The Hungarian and Slovak positions illustrate a fundamental tension within the CEE region that the war has sharpened rather than resolved. The shared historical experience of Soviet domination and the shared aspiration for Euro-Atlantic integration have not produced a uniform strategic culture; instead, they have coexisted with the emergence of populist nationalist movements that prioritize bilateral relations with Russia over collective Western solidarity and that exploit economic dependencies—particularly in the energy sector—to justify positions that effectively serve Russian strategic interests. The management of this internal CEE dissent has become one of the central diplomatic challenges for both the European Union and NATO in the post-invasion period.

2.5 Romania, Bulgaria, Czech Republic: The Middle Ground

Between the frontline assertiveness of Poland and the Baltic states and the obstructive dissent of Hungary and Slovakia, a significant portion of CEE's diplomatic landscape was occupied by states navigating a more complex middle course. Romania, Bulgaria, and the Czech Republic each brought distinctive historical experiences and domestic political constraints to their responses to the invasion, producing trajectories that evolved substantially over the course of the conflict.

Romania's response was shaped by its Black Sea geography, its historical memory of Soviet occupation, and a domestic political landscape that, despite periodic turbulence, maintained a strong cross-party consensus on Euro-Atlantic integration. Bucharest moved relatively quickly to reinforce its hosting of NATO assets, including the Aegis Ashore ballistic missile defense system at Deveselu, and advocated for increased Alliance presence on its territory and in the Black Sea region. Romania's strategic significance—it shares a lengthy border with Ukraine and Moldova and provides NATO with critical access to the Black Sea—was immediately recognized, and Allied attention to Romanian security requests increased correspondingly. Romania also played an important role in managing the transit of Ukrainian grain exports following Russia's blockade of Black Sea ports, as alternative land and river routes through Romanian territory became essential to maintaining global food supply chains.

Bulgaria's response was more tentative, reflecting the particular depth of historical and cultural ties between Bulgaria and Russia—ties rooted in the prominent role of Russian military power in Bulgarian national liberation from Ottoman rule in the 19th century and reinforced by decades of particularly close Soviet-Bulgarian relations. The Bulgarian government initially struggled to build parliamentary consensus for the provision of military assistance to Ukraine, with the question of arms transfers generating significant political controversy. Over time, and through successive governments, Bulgaria moved toward greater alignment with the EU and NATO consensus, though its contribution to Ukrainian defense remained more limited than that of most CEE states.

The Czech Republic distinguished itself by the practical imagination and diplomatic energy of its arms provision to Ukraine. Prague facilitated the transfer of significant quantities of Soviet-era compatible weapons and ammunition from various global sources, organizing what amounted to an informal international procurement network that matched Ukrainian needs with available supplies from third countries. The Czech "ammunition initiative," launched in early 2024 and ultimately joined by numerous European partners, exemplified the kind of practical problem-solving that characterized Prague's contribution to the collective response. Domestically, the Czech Republic maintained a strong political consensus in favor of Ukrainian support across its major parties, providing a degree of policy continuity that contrasted favorably with the volatility seen elsewhere in the region.

2.6 The UN and Multilateral Diplomacy: CEE as a Collective Actor

At the level of multilateral diplomacy, the war produced a significant evolution in the collective agency of CEE states within international institutions. The United Nations General Assembly became the primary arena for measuring and contesting the international community's response to the invasion, and the consistent advocacy of CEE states in building and maintaining the majority supporting resolutions condemning Russian aggression represented a meaningful diplomatic contribution that extended well beyond the region's formal voting weight.

The CEE states coordinated their diplomatic efforts with considerable effectiveness, presenting a largely unified front in General Assembly debates and in the various UN bodies tasked with documenting Russian violations of international humanitarian law. The International Criminal Court's issuance of arrest warrants for Vladimir Putin and Maria Lvova-Belova in March 2023—related to the unlawful deportation of Ukrainian children—was supported by vigorous advocacy from CEE governments, several of which had been

instrumental in documenting the relevant evidence and building political support for the ICC's jurisdiction.

Within the European Union, the CEE states worked to shape the institutional response to the invasion, advocating for the acceleration of Ukrainian EU membership negotiations, the maintenance of sanctions pressure on Russia, and the deepening of European defense integration. The formal granting of EU candidate status to Ukraine and Moldova in June 2022 represented a significant diplomatic achievement that owed much to the advocacy of CEE member states, who argued with considerable force that the geopolitical moment demanded a political signal of the clearest possible kind. The subsequent opening of accession negotiations with Ukraine in June 2024 represented a further milestone in a process that CEE states had consistently championed against the hesitations of some Western European partners concerned about the institutional and financial implications of Ukrainian membership.

The emergence of CEE as a more coherent and assertive collective diplomatic actor represents one of the most significant structural consequences of the invasion. A region that had historically been the object rather than the subject of great power diplomacy has begun, haltingly but perceptibly, to function as a strategic actor capable of shaping the decisions of the institutions of which it is a member. This transformation is incomplete, uneven, and complicated by the internal divisions exemplified by the Hungarian and Slovak cases; but it is real, and its implications for the future architecture of European international relations are profound.

Chapter 3. Security Architecture Reimagined: NATO's Eastern Flank

3.1 NATO Before 2022: The "Brain Death" Debate

The state of NATO in the years immediately preceding the Russian invasion of Ukraine was, to put it charitably, one of considerable internal tension. The Alliance that emerged from the Cold War had struggled for three decades to define a coherent strategic purpose in a security environment that appeared, to many of its most influential members, to have moved decisively beyond the existential confrontations of the 20th century. The "out of area or out of business" debate of the 1990s had produced a NATO deeply invested in expeditionary operations—the Balkans, Afghanistan, Libya—at the expense of its original and foundational mission of collective territorial defense against a major conventional adversary.

The most dramatic expression of this institutional disorientation came in November 2019, when French President Emmanuel Macron, in an interview with *The Economist*,

described NATO as experiencing "brain death." Macron's provocative characterization pointed to a genuine dysfunction: the absence of strategic coordination between Alliance members, the unilateral Turkish military operations in Syria conducted without consultation with NATO partners, and the persistent uncertainty generated by the Trump administration's ambivalent attitude toward Article 5 collective defense commitments. The French president's proposed remedy—greater European strategic autonomy and a fundamental renegotiation of the transatlantic relationship—was received with considerable irritation in Washington and in the capitals of Eastern Europe, where it was interpreted as a potentially dangerous signal of Western European disengagement from the Alliance's eastern commitments precisely at a moment of growing Russian assertiveness.

For the CEE states, the "brain death" episode encapsulated their broader frustration with NATO's institutional culture. The Alliance's strategic concept in force before 2022—adopted at the Lisbon Summit in 2010—had characterized Russia as a "strategic partner" and made no provision for the kind of large-scale territorial defense operations that the security environments of Poland and the Baltic states clearly required. The Enhanced Forward Presence established after 2016 represented an important symbolic commitment but an inadequate operational response; the four multinational battle groups deployed to Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, and Poland numbered approximately 4,500 troops in total—a force that, as military planners in Tallinn and Warsaw were acutely aware, could not realistically contest a serious Russian conventional assault.

The Alliance's defense planning processes had similarly failed to keep pace with the changed security environment. For much of the post-Cold War period, NATO had maintained no detailed operational plans for the defense of its Baltic members against a Russian conventional attack—a planning gap that reflected the prevailing assumption that such an attack was too improbable to warrant serious contingency planning. When the assumption was revisited in the aftermath of 2014, the resulting plans were judged by many military professionals within the Alliance to be inadequate to the scale of the threat. The RAND Corporation's influential 2016 war-game analysis concluded that Russian forces could reach the outskirts of Tallinn and Riga within 60 hours of initiating an attack, before NATO reinforcements could be effectively deployed—a finding that generated considerable alarm within the Alliance but only limited change in its actual force posture.

3.2 The Madrid Summit 2022 and the New Strategic Concept

The NATO Summit held in Madrid in late June 2022, four months after the invasion of Ukraine, produced what many analysts have characterized as the most significant reorientation of Alliance strategy since the end of the Cold War. The new Strategic Concept adopted at Madrid replaced the 2010 document's characterization of Russia as a strategic partner with an unambiguous designation of Russia as "the most significant and direct threat to Allies' security and to peace and stability in the Euro-Atlantic area." This rhetorical shift, while seemingly straightforward, carried substantial implications for Alliance planning, force posture, and resource allocation.

The Madrid Strategic Concept also addressed, for the first time with such clarity, the challenge posed by China, characterizing Beijing's "stated ambitions and coercive policies" as a challenge to Alliance interests, security, and values. This formulation reflected the growing recognition within the Alliance that the security environment of the 21st century was defined not by a single revisionist power but by an increasingly coordinated challenge from authoritarian states willing to use coercion and force to reshape the international order. For CEE states, the China dimension of the new strategic concept was secondary to the immediate Russian threat, but the global framing of Alliance strategy was broadly welcomed as an indication that the United States remained committed to a transatlantic security partnership capable of addressing threats beyond the European theater.

On the specific question of NATO's posture in Eastern Europe, the Madrid Summit decisions were far-reaching. The Alliance committed to a fundamental transformation of its Enhanced Forward Presence, upgrading the existing battle groups to brigade-level formations and establishing plans for the prepositioning of significantly greater quantities of equipment, ammunition, and supplies in the eastern member states. The New Force Model, announced at Madrid, envisioned a NATO force of 300,000 troops at high readiness—a dramatic increase from the pre-invasion posture and a direct response to the demonstrated scale and intensity of Russian conventional military operations in Ukraine.

Finland and Sweden's formal applications for NATO membership, submitted in May 2022 and received with enthusiastic support by the Alliance's eastern members, were welcomed at the Madrid Summit, setting in motion accession processes that would be completed—for Finland in April 2023 and Sweden in March 2024—with remarkable speed by the standards of Alliance enlargement. The strategic implications of Nordic accession for CEE security were profound, as the subsequent section will address in detail.

3.3 Enhanced Forward Presence: From Tripwire to Combat-Ready

The transformation of NATO's Enhanced Forward Presence from a symbolic tripwire into a genuinely combat-capable defensive posture has been among the most consequential and concrete security developments of the post-invasion period. The process has been neither uniform nor complete, but its trajectory represents a fundamental departure from the strategic assumptions that governed Alliance force planning for the preceding three decades.

In the Baltic states, the upgrade of battle groups to brigade-level formations represented a qualitative shift in the nature of NATO's commitment. A brigade—typically comprising between 3,000 and 5,000 troops with organic armor, artillery, and support elements—is a genuinely combined-arms formation capable of sustained defensive operations, as distinct from the battalion-sized battle groups of the Enhanced Forward Presence that were designed primarily to ensure that any Russian attack would unavoidably engage Allied forces and thus trigger Article 5. The British-led battle group in Estonia, the Canadian-led group in Latvia, and the German-led group in Lithuania all began the process of expansion toward brigade-level capability, with the host nations committing to provide the infrastructure, basing, and national brigade formations that would work alongside the Allied contingents.

Germany's commitment to Lithuania was particularly significant given Berlin's historically cautious approach to military deployments on NATO's eastern frontier. The announcement in 2022 that Germany would establish a permanent brigade-level presence in Lithuania—the first permanent stationing of German combat forces abroad since the Second World War—represented a remarkable departure from the self-imposed restraints of post-war German strategic culture. The implementation of this commitment proved more complex than the initial announcement suggested, with logistical, financial, and political challenges delaying the full deployment, but the strategic signal was clear: Germany had accepted, however reluctantly, that the defense of Eastern Europe required a permanent rather than rotational military commitment.

In Poland, the transformation was even more dramatic. The United States had already established a permanent military presence in Poland prior to the invasion—the establishment of US Army V Corps forward headquarters in Poznań in 2021 was a significant milestone—but the scale of the American military footprint expanded substantially after February 2022. The US deployed additional troops, armor, and air defense systems to Polish territory, and the two countries signed a bilateral Enhanced Defense Cooperation Agreement that provided the legal framework for an expanded and more permanent American military presence. The positioning of Patriot air defense batteries in Poland, later supplemented by additional systems following

the tragic incident in November 2022 when a Ukrainian air defense missile struck Polish territory near the border, underscored the operational reality of Poland's status as a frontline state.

The transformation of NATO's physical presence in the region was accompanied by a revolution in Alliance defense planning. The classified operational plans developed by NATO's military authorities after 2022 represented a fundamental departure from the minimal planning of the preceding decade, incorporating detailed provisions for the rapid reinforcement of eastern member states, the designation of specific national contributions to the defense of specific Alliance territories, and the identification of the infrastructure improvements necessary to support the movement of large military formations across the Alliance's eastern approaches. The Regional Plans, approved by Alliance leaders at the Vilnius Summit in 2023, provided the first comprehensive framework for territorial defense since the Cold War and represented a genuine institutional achievement that the CEE states had been advocating for years.

3.4 Finland and Sweden: The End of Nordic Neutrality

The accession of Finland and Sweden to NATO membership constitutes one of the most strategically consequential consequences of Russia's invasion of Ukraine—and one of the most striking examples of the law of unintended consequences in modern geopolitics. For decades, both countries had maintained carefully cultivated postures of military non-alignment, rooted in different historical experiences but producing a similar strategic outcome: the preservation of a degree of distance from the bloc confrontations of the Cold War and a self-conception as neutral or at least non-aligned states capable of acting as bridges or mediators in international disputes.

Finland's neutrality was the more constrained of the two, shaped by the specific legacy of the Winter War of 1939–1940 and the Continuation War of 1941–1944, and by the subsequent experience of "Finlandization"—the pragmatic self-limitation of Finnish foreign policy to avoid provoking Soviet sensitivities. Despite this constraint, Finland had built one of the most capable and serious defense establishments in Europe, maintaining a large conscript army, substantial artillery reserves, and a sophisticated understanding of how to defend its long border with Russia. The Finnish defense forces had never ceased planning for exactly the kind of large-scale conventional assault that Russia launched against Ukraine, and the institutional knowledge and military capacity that this planning produced meant that Finland's NATO membership immediately added genuine military value to the Alliance rather than merely symbolic weight.

Sweden's path to NATO was shaped by a longer tradition of voluntary neutrality, rooted in the country's remarkable achievement of avoiding involvement in the conflicts of the 20th century. Swedish strategic culture had long emphasized diplomatic mediation, arms control, and the management of international disputes through multilateral institutions. The decision to apply for NATO membership represented a profound rupture with this tradition—one that was debated intensely within Swedish society and that encountered significant domestic resistance before ultimately achieving broad political consensus in the face of the Russian invasion's implications.

For the Baltic Sea region, the strategic implications of Nordic accession were transformative. Prior to Finland and Sweden joining NATO, the Baltic Sea was a semi-enclosed body of water in which Russia retained significant access and in which the three Baltic states were accessible by sea only through waters that could potentially be contested by Russian naval and air forces. With Finland and Sweden as Alliance members, the Baltic Sea became, in effect, a NATO lake—with Alliance territory surrounding the sea on all sides except for the Russian naval base at Kaliningrad and the Russian coast in the Gulf of Finland. This geographic transformation fundamentally altered the calculus of any potential Russian military operation in the region, severely constraining Moscow's ability to project power into the Baltic maritime environment and dramatically improving the Alliance's capacity to reinforce and supply the Baltic states in a crisis.

The implications extended beyond the Baltic. Finland's accession more than doubled the length of NATO's land border with Russia, from approximately 750 kilometers to nearly 2,600 kilometers. From a purely geographic perspective, this represented an enormous expansion of the Alliance's exposure, but from a strategic perspective, it represented an equally enormous expansion of the defensive depth and the number of axes along which any Russian military planning would need to contend with NATO forces. The Russian military, already fully committed in Ukraine, faced the prospect of having to plan for the defense of a vastly extended border with a significantly strengthened adversarial alliance—a strategic deterioration of Russia's security position that was the direct and ironic consequence of Putin's decision to invade Ukraine.

3.5 Military Spending Revolution in CEE

The Russian invasion triggered a revolution in defense spending across Central and Eastern Europe that has no precedent in the post-Cold War period. States that had spent decades struggling to meet NATO's two percent of GDP defense spending guideline, or that had never

met it at all, moved rapidly and dramatically to expand their defense budgets, accelerate military procurement, and rebuild force structures that had been hollowed out by the strategic assumptions of the preceding era.

Poland's trajectory was the most dramatic of any NATO member. Warsaw had already begun a substantial defense buildup before the invasion, driven by its assessment of Russian intentions, but the events of February 2022 accelerated this process into something resembling a wartime mobilization of the defense industrial base. Poland committed to spending four percent of its GDP on defense—double the NATO guideline and the highest percentage of any Alliance member—and embarked on an unprecedented procurement program that included the purchase of 250 M1A2 Abrams main battle tanks from the United States, 180 K2 Black Panther tanks from South Korea, over 600 K9 self-propelled howitzers, F-35 multirole fighters, and a range of additional systems across multiple domains. The scale of Polish procurement was so large that it strained the capacity of supplier nations to deliver on contracted timelines and generated significant discussion within the Alliance about the implications of such a rapid buildup for regional military balances.

The Baltic states similarly expanded their defense commitments with remarkable speed and determination. Estonia, which had consistently been among the few NATO members to meet the two percent guideline throughout the preceding decade, committed to raising its defense spending to three percent of GDP. Latvia and Lithuania, which had previously struggled to meet the two percent target, moved rapidly to exceed it. All three Baltic states accelerated their investments in air defense, anti-armor systems, and the munitions stocks necessary to sustain extended defensive operations—drawing on the lessons of the Ukrainian conflict regarding the enormous consumption rates of artillery ammunition in modern conventional warfare.

Romania committed to a substantial increase in defense spending and accelerated the modernization of its armed forces, with particular attention to air defense and naval capabilities relevant to the Black Sea theater. The Czech Republic, despite a more modest economy, maintained a strong commitment to defense spending increases and distinguished itself through its practical contributions to Ukrainian defense and the facilitation of ammunition procurement through its well-developed defense industry.

The broader implications of this spending revolution extend beyond the immediate military capabilities being acquired. The rapid expansion of defense budgets across CEE has created a new political economy of security in the region, with defense industry investment generating employment, technological development, and economic activity that create their

own constituencies for sustained military spending. The decision of several CEE states to develop or expand domestic defense production capacity—Poland’s investment in its domestic defense industry being the most prominent example—represents a long-term strategic commitment that will shape the region’s security posture for decades. The Korean defense industry’s deep engagement in the CEE market, exemplified by the massive contracts signed with Poland, has also introduced a new set of bilateral relationships with significant strategic implications, connecting the security architectures of the Euro-Atlantic and Indo-Pacific regions in novel ways.

3.6 Ukraine and NATO: The Question of Membership

Perhaps no issue in the Alliance’s post-invasion deliberations has proven more contentious or more consequential than the question of Ukraine’s path to NATO membership. The tension between the political and moral case for offering Ukraine a clear and credible membership perspective and the strategic concerns about escalation, Alliance cohesion, and the practical challenges of admitting a state actively engaged in a major conventional war has defined much of the internal Alliance debate since February 2022.

The Vilnius Summit of July 2023 produced a formulation that satisfied no one entirely. The communiqué reaffirmed that "Ukraine’s future is in NATO" and removed the requirement for Ukraine to submit a Membership Action Plan—a significant procedural advancement—but declined to issue a formal invitation or to specify a timeline for membership. The compromise reflected the divergent positions within the Alliance: the United States and Germany, in particular, were reluctant to make commitments that might be interpreted as directly involving NATO in the conflict, while Poland, the Baltic states, and most of the CEE member states argued vigorously for a stronger and more explicit commitment.

For the CEE states, Ukraine’s NATO membership was not merely a question of solidarity with a neighbor under attack but a matter of direct security interest. The argument was straightforward: a Ukraine that remained outside NATO would remain a target for Russian pressure and potential renewed aggression indefinitely, creating a permanent zone of instability on the Alliance’s eastern border. Only Ukrainian membership, or at minimum ironclad security guarantees of a kind that only Alliance membership could realistically provide, would create the stable security environment that CEE states required for their own long-term security. The bilateral security commitments that the G7 nations and other partners negotiated with Ukraine in 2024, inspired by the model of the Israel-US security relationship, represented a partial and

interim response to this concern, but most CEE governments regarded them as insufficient substitutes for full membership.

The Washington Summit of July 2024 produced further incremental progress, describing Ukraine's path to NATO membership as "irreversible"—a formulation carefully chosen to be stronger than previous communiqués while stopping short of an invitation. The CEE states welcomed this language while acknowledging that the fundamental question of timing and conditions remained unresolved. The underlying tension between the security imperative of integrating Ukraine into the Alliance and the escalation concerns of key Western members continues to define one of the central diplomatic fault lines within NATO as the conflict enters its fourth year.

3.7 Nuclear Deterrence and the Escalation Dilemma

No aspect of NATO's response to the invasion of Ukraine was more fraught or more consequential than the management of nuclear deterrence and the escalation dilemma. Russia's repeated invocations of its nuclear arsenal—from Putin's initial announcement that Russia's nuclear forces had been placed on heightened alert in February 2022 to the subsequent series of thinly veiled threats regarding the consequences of Western military assistance to Ukraine—created a diplomatic and strategic environment in which every decision about the nature and scale of support to Ukraine was filtered through the prism of escalation risk.

For the CEE states, Russia's nuclear rhetoric was viewed with a combination of alarm and considerable skepticism. The alarm was genuine: the prospect of nuclear escalation represented an existential threat to the entire region, and the geographic proximity of CEE states to the likely theater of any nuclear exchange made the stakes viscerally concrete. The skepticism, however, was equally genuine and rooted in a long historical experience of Russian intimidation tactics. The Baltic states and Poland, in particular, argued consistently that yielding to Russian nuclear threats would only validate and encourage their future use, creating a permanent veto over Western support for any state that Russia chose to target with nuclear coercion.

The Alliance navigated this dilemma through a combination of private signaling, public restraint, and graduated escalation management. The United States and its allies communicated clearly to Moscow—through multiple channels and at the highest levels—that any use of nuclear weapons would produce consequences severe enough to constitute an existential threat to the Russian state, without specifying precisely what those consequences would be. This deliberate

ambiguity was designed to preserve deterrent credibility while avoiding public commitments that might constrain Allied options or provide Moscow with clear red lines to approach.

The debate about nuclear sharing arrangements within CEE also intensified following the invasion. Poland's exploration of the possibility of participating in NATO's nuclear sharing mission—potentially hosting US nuclear weapons under the existing NATO nuclear sharing arrangements—reflected the broader regional discussion about whether the current distribution of nuclear deterrence assets within the Alliance was appropriately calibrated to the changed threat environment. These discussions remained sensitive and were conducted largely out of public view, but they represented a significant evolution in the nuclear dimension of CEE's security debate—one that would have been difficult to imagine in the more optimistic strategic environment of the preceding decade.

Chapter 4. Economic Consequences and New Dependencies

4.1 The Energy Shock: Decoupling from Russian Hydrocarbons

The economic dimension of Russia's invasion of Ukraine produced what can only be described as the most severe energy shock to the European continent since the oil crises of the 1970s. For Central and Eastern Europe, the shock was particularly acute because the region's energy infrastructure had been constructed during the Soviet period specifically to ensure dependence on Russian supply chains—a structural legacy that decades of post-Cold War economic liberalization had failed to fully overcome.

Prior to February 2022, the extent of CEE's energy dependence on Russia was staggering in both its scale and its strategic implications. The Baltic states received virtually all of their natural gas from Russia through pipeline systems designed during the Soviet era. Poland, despite years of deliberate diversification efforts including the construction of the Świnoujście LNG terminal, still relied on Russia for approximately 40 percent of its gas supplies. Slovakia, Hungary, and the Czech Republic were even more heavily dependent, with Russian gas constituting between 65 and 85 percent of their total consumption. Bulgaria and Romania, while somewhat less dependent on Russian gas, remained significant consumers of Russian crude oil and refined petroleum products. The dependency extended beyond hydrocarbons: several CEE states, notably the Czech Republic, Slovakia, Hungary, and Bulgaria, operated nuclear power plants built with Soviet technology and reliant on Russian-supplied nuclear fuel assemblies—a dependency that could not be rapidly or easily diversified given the technical specificity of the fuel and reactor designs involved.

The invasion transformed this dependency from a chronic strategic vulnerability into an acute economic crisis. Russia's progressive weaponization of its gas supplies throughout 2022—reducing flows through the Nord Stream pipeline system to a trickle and ultimately halting them entirely, coupled with the mysterious destruction of the Nord Stream 1 and 2 pipelines in September 2022—forced CEE states to undertake emergency diversification measures at enormous financial cost and under severe time pressure. The price of natural gas on European spot markets reached extraordinary levels in the summer of 2022, with the Dutch TTF benchmark exceeding 300 euros per megawatt-hour—roughly ten times the pre-crisis price—before gradually declining as alternative supply arrangements were established and demand was curtailed through a combination of mild weather, conservation measures, and industrial production reductions.

The responses of individual CEE states to the energy crisis reflected their varying starting positions and political orientations. Poland's situation was comparatively favorable because Warsaw had invested heavily in alternative infrastructure in the preceding years. The Baltic Pipe, connecting Poland to Norwegian gas fields through Denmark, was inaugurated in September 2022—a project whose strategic foresight was retrospectively vindicated by events. The expansion of the Świnoujście LNG terminal and the construction of a floating LNG terminal at Gdańsk provided additional import capacity, enabling Poland to achieve effective independence from Russian gas supplies by the end of 2022.

Lithuania had made similar preparations, commissioning the Klaipėda floating LNG terminal—symbolically named "Independence"—as early as 2014, following Russia's initial aggression against Ukraine. This investment, criticized at the time as economically irrational given the higher cost of LNG compared to Russian pipeline gas, proved to be among the most prescient infrastructure decisions made by any CEE state in the post-Cold War period. Latvia and Estonia, which lacked their own LNG import capacity, benefited from regional interconnections with Lithuania and Finland, as well as from the development of emergency supply arrangements coordinated at the EU level.

Hungary and Slovakia, by contrast, maintained their reliance on Russian gas supplies throughout the crisis, exploiting exemptions negotiated within the EU sanctions framework and pipeline routes through Turkey and the TurkStream system. Budapest's insistence on preserving its energy relationship with Moscow became one of the most contentious elements of intra-European diplomacy, with critics arguing that Hungary's energy dependency served as both an economic justification and a political cover for Orbán's broader strategic accommodation of Russian interests.

4.2 Sanctions Regime and Its Economic Impact on CEE

The sanctions imposed by the European Union, the United States, and their partners on Russia in response to the invasion represented the most comprehensive economic restrictions ever applied to a major world economy. For Central and Eastern Europe, the sanctions regime produced a complex mixture of economic costs, strategic benefits, and distributional effects that varied significantly across the region.

The EU sanctions packages, adopted in rapid succession through 2022 and subsequently expanded and refined, targeted the Russian financial system, energy exports, technology imports, and the personal assets of individuals associated with the Putin regime. The exclusion of major Russian banks from the SWIFT international payments system, the restrictions on Russian Central Bank reserves held in Western jurisdictions, and the progressive embargo on Russian crude oil and refined petroleum products constituted a direct assault on the revenue streams that financed Russia's war machine. For CEE states, these measures carried both symbolic and practical significance: they represented a collective Western commitment to imposing costs on Russian aggression that exceeded anything previously attempted, while simultaneously imposing costs on the CEE economies that implemented them.

The economic impact on CEE was felt most acutely through three channels. First, the energy price shock transmitted inflationary pressure throughout the region's economies, driving consumer price inflation to levels not experienced since the turbulent transition period of the 1990s. Poland's annual inflation rate exceeded 17 percent in 2022, while the Baltic states experienced even higher rates—Lithuania's inflation peaked at over 22 percent. These inflationary pressures were particularly burdensome for lower-income households and generated significant social and political strain, complicating governments' ability to maintain public support for Ukraine-related policies.

Second, the disruption of trade relationships with Russia imposed direct costs on CEE industries and businesses that had maintained significant commercial ties with the Russian market. While the aggregate trade volumes were modest relative to the size of CEE economies—intra-EU trade far exceeded trade with Russia for all CEE member states—specific sectors and regions were disproportionately affected. The transport and logistics sectors in the Baltic states, which had historically handled significant volumes of Russian transit trade, experienced substantial revenue losses. Agricultural producers in several CEE states lost access to the Russian market, though the aggregate impact was mitigated by the redirection of trade toward other markets.

Third, and perhaps most significantly for the long-term economic trajectory of the region, the sanctions regime accelerated a broader process of economic decoupling from Russia that extended well beyond the specific sectors targeted by sanctions. The reputational and compliance risks associated with maintaining business relationships involving Russian counterparties led many CEE firms to withdraw from the Russian market entirely, even in sectors not directly covered by sanctions. This voluntary decoupling, driven by commercial prudence rather than legal obligation, contributed to a comprehensive restructuring of trade patterns that is likely to prove durable regardless of the eventual resolution of the conflict.

4.3 Ukraine's Economic Integration with CEE

The war paradoxically accelerated the economic integration of Ukraine with its Central and Eastern European neighbors, creating new trade flows, labor market linkages, and institutional relationships that are reshaping the economic geography of the region. This integration has been driven by a combination of emergency wartime measures, deliberate policy choices, and the organic adjustments of markets and populations responding to extraordinary circumstances.

The European Union's decision to suspend customs duties and quotas on Ukrainian exports—the Autonomous Trade Measures adopted in June 2022—opened EU markets to Ukrainian goods on terms more favorable than those provided under the existing Association Agreement. For Ukrainian producers, the CEE states represented the most geographically accessible and logistically feasible markets, and trade flows adjusted accordingly. Ukrainian agricultural exports, in particular, increasingly transited through or were destined for CEE markets, generating both economic opportunities and significant political tensions.

The "grain crisis" of 2023 illustrated the complexity of Ukraine's economic integration with CEE with particular clarity. The massive volumes of Ukrainian grain transiting through Poland, Romania, Hungary, Slovakia, and Bulgaria en route to global markets depressed local grain prices and generated intense political pressure from domestic agricultural lobbies. Poland, Hungary, Slovakia, Romania, and Bulgaria imposed unilateral temporary import bans on Ukrainian agricultural products—measures that were partially sanctioned by the European Commission but that generated considerable diplomatic friction with Kyiv. The episode revealed the tensions inherent in rapid economic integration: the same CEE states that were most vociferous in their political and military support for Ukraine proved equally vocal in defending their domestic economic interests when those interests were perceived to be threatened by Ukrainian competition.

The labor market dimension of Ukraine's integration with CEE has been equally significant, though less politically contentious. The millions of Ukrainian refugees who settled in CEE states—primarily Poland, the Czech Republic, Romania, and the Baltic states—entered local labor markets in substantial numbers, contributing to economic activity and partially alleviating labor shortages in sectors such as construction, manufacturing, services, and healthcare. Poland, which hosted the largest Ukrainian refugee population, experienced a particularly significant integration of Ukrainian workers into its economy, building on the substantial pre-war Ukrainian labor migration that had already made Ukrainians the largest foreign workforce in the country.

The institutional framework for Ukraine's economic integration with Europe also advanced significantly during this period. The formal opening of EU accession negotiations in June 2024 initiated a process of regulatory alignment and institutional reform that, while undoubtedly lengthy and complex, established a clear trajectory toward full economic integration. For CEE states that had themselves undergone this process in the 1990s and 2000s, the Ukrainian accession process represented both a familiar challenge and a strategic priority, and several CEE governments—notably Poland, the Czech Republic, and the Baltic states—committed to providing technical assistance and sharing institutional expertise to support Ukraine's reform efforts.

4.4 Defense Industry Boom in CEE

The war in Ukraine generated an unprecedented boom in the defense industries of Central and Eastern Europe, transforming a sector that had been marginal to the region's post-Cold War economic development into a strategic priority attracting substantial investment, political attention, and international partnerships. The scale and intensity of conventional warfare in Ukraine—with its enormous consumption of artillery ammunition, armored vehicles, air defense systems, and electronic warfare equipment—revealed the inadequacy of Western defense industrial capacity and created both an urgent need and a lucrative market opportunity for expanded production.

Poland's defense industrial ambitions were the most expansive in the region. Warsaw's massive procurement programs—the Abrams tanks, K2 Black Panther tanks, K9 howitzers, F-35 fighters, and numerous other systems—were accompanied by deliberate efforts to build domestic production capacity and technology transfer arrangements. The agreements with South Korean defense firms, in particular, included provisions for the licensed production of significant portions of the contracted systems in Polish factories, with the explicit objective of

creating a self-sustaining Polish defense industrial base capable of producing advanced military equipment for both domestic use and export. The Polish government established the National Defense Holding Company (PGZ) as the institutional framework for this industrial strategy, consolidating state-owned defense enterprises and directing investment toward the expansion of production capacity.

The Czech Republic leveraged its existing defense industrial base—a legacy of Czechoslovakia’s substantial arms industry—to play an outsized role in the provision of ammunition and weapons to Ukraine. Czech firms produced and brokered the sale of significant quantities of Soviet-caliber ammunition compatible with Ukraine’s existing weapons systems, and Prague’s ammunition initiative mobilized international funding to purchase available stocks from countries around the world. The Czech defense industry’s combination of technical capability, commercial agility, and familiarity with Soviet-era weapons systems made it a uniquely valuable contributor to the Ukrainian war effort and generated substantial commercial returns for Czech defense firms.

Romania accelerated its defense industrial development with particular attention to the aerospace and naval sectors. The establishment of a European ammunition production facility and Romania’s participation in multinational defense industrial cooperation programs reflected Bucharest’s recognition that the defense sector represented both a strategic necessity and an economic opportunity. The Bulgarian defense industry, despite the country’s more ambiguous political positioning, also experienced increased demand for its products—particularly ammunition and small arms—as global demand for military equipment surged.

The defense industrial boom in CEE carries long-term economic implications that extend well beyond the immediate conflict. The region is positioning itself as a significant center of European defense production, complementing and potentially competing with the traditional defense industrial powers of Western Europe. This development creates new economic constituencies with vested interests in sustained defense spending, potentially altering the political economy of security policy in the region for decades to come.

4.5 EU Funds and Recovery Mechanisms

The European Union’s financial response to the combined crises of the pandemic, the energy shock, and the war in Ukraine channeled substantial resources toward Central and Eastern Europe through a variety of mechanisms that have significantly shaped the region’s economic trajectory. The intersection of existing EU funding instruments with new programs

designed to address the specific consequences of the conflict created a complex financial landscape that has had both intended and unintended consequences for CEE economies.

The RePowerEU plan, adopted in May 2022 as the EU's strategic response to the energy crisis, directed significant investment toward the diversification of energy supplies, the acceleration of renewable energy deployment, and the improvement of energy efficiency across the EU. For CEE states, RePowerEU provided both financial resources and regulatory incentives for the energy transition that the region had been slow to pursue in the preceding years. The plan's provisions for accelerated permitting of renewable energy projects, investment in cross-border energy interconnectors, and support for the development of hydrogen infrastructure were particularly relevant to CEE states seeking to reduce their dependence on Russian hydrocarbons and to modernize energy systems that remained heavily reliant on coal and imported gas.

The Recovery and Resilience Facility (RRF), originally established to support post-pandemic recovery, was adapted to incorporate RePowerEU objectives, providing additional financial resources for energy-related investments. Poland's access to its RRF allocation—long delayed due to the European Commission's concerns about rule of law—was partially unlocked in 2024, providing a substantial fiscal boost to the Polish economy and enabling investments in areas ranging from energy infrastructure to digital transformation. The conditionality attached to these funds—requiring reforms in judicial independence and other areas of democratic governance—created a complex dynamic in which EU financial support simultaneously promoted economic development and institutional reform.

The Ukraine Facility, a dedicated €50 billion support package adopted by the EU in February 2024, represented the most significant financial commitment to a non-member state in the Union's history. While the funds were directed to Ukraine rather than to CEE member states, the facility had significant indirect economic implications for the region. The reconstruction and recovery spending envisioned by the facility would necessarily involve substantial procurement from CEE firms, creating economic opportunities for construction companies, industrial suppliers, and service providers across the region. The prospect of Ukrainian EU membership, supported by the accession negotiations opened in 2024, further reinforced the expectation that economic integration between Ukraine and CEE would deepen substantially in the coming years.

The intersection of these various EU financial mechanisms with national fiscal policies produced a period of significant public investment across CEE—investment in defense, energy, infrastructure, and digital transformation that collectively amounted to an economic stimulus

of considerable scale. The macroeconomic consequences were mixed: while the investment supported growth and modernization, the inflationary pressures generated by the energy crisis and by the demand-side effects of military spending created challenges for monetary policy and household living standards that were acutely felt across the region.

4.6 Long-Term Economic Realignment

The cumulative effect of the developments described in the preceding sections—energy decoupling, sanctions-driven trade restructuring, defense industrial expansion, Ukrainian economic integration, and EU-funded investment—amounts to a fundamental realignment of CEE’s economic orientation with long-term structural implications.

The most significant dimension of this realignment is the decisive severing of the economic relationship between CEE and Russia. Prior to 2022, the economic ties between the region and Moscow, while diminishing in relative importance, remained substantial in absolute terms and strategically significant in specific sectors—above all energy. The combination of sanctions, voluntary decoupling, and infrastructure investment has reduced the Russian share of CEE trade and energy consumption to levels that, for most states in the region, are approaching negligibility. This decoupling is unlikely to be reversed even in the event of a cessation of hostilities and a partial normalization of relations with Moscow, because the infrastructure investments, alternative supply relationships, and reputational considerations that drove the decoupling will persist regardless of the political environment.

The reorientation of CEE trade patterns toward the European single market, toward the transatlantic relationship, and toward new partnerships with Asian suppliers—particularly South Korea and Japan in the defense and technology sectors—is producing a more diversified and potentially more resilient economic structure. The region’s role as a manufacturing hub for European and global supply chains, already substantial before the invasion, has been reinforced by the combination of competitive labor costs, improving infrastructure, geographic proximity to major European markets, and the perceived strategic advantage of locating production capacity in NATO and EU member states rather than in geopolitically uncertain environments.

The emergence of CEE as a significant center of defense production introduces a new economic sector with distinct characteristics and implications. Defense industry investment tends to be long-term, technologically intensive, and closely linked to state policy, creating economic relationships between governments and private sector actors that can shape broader patterns of political economy. The integration of CEE defense industries into transatlantic and global supply chains—through partnerships with American, Korean, and Western European

firms—is creating a network of economic interdependencies that reinforce the strategic alignment of the region with the broader Western alliance.

The prospect of Ukrainian economic integration adds a further dimension of uncertainty and opportunity. A successfully reformed and integrated Ukrainian economy would represent a market of over 40 million consumers with substantial agricultural, industrial, and technological potential. For CEE states, particularly Poland, Romania, and the Baltic states, the development of the Ukrainian economy represents a significant potential source of trade, investment, and growth. The reconstruction of war-damaged Ukrainian infrastructure alone constitutes an investment opportunity of enormous scale, estimated by the World Bank at over \$400 billion, and CEE firms are well-positioned to capture a substantial share of this market given their geographic proximity, institutional familiarity, and technical expertise.

However, the economic realignment also carries risks and vulnerabilities. The inflationary consequences of the energy shock and defense spending have imposed real costs on CEE populations, and the political sustainability of policies that prioritize strategic objectives over short-term economic welfare cannot be taken for granted. The grain crisis of 2023 demonstrated that the economic integration of Ukraine can generate significant distributional conflicts within CEE, and managing these conflicts will require diplomatic skill and institutional flexibility. The long-term fiscal sustainability of dramatically increased defense spending, while currently supported by political consensus, may come under pressure as competing demands on public budgets intensify.

Chapter 5. New Regional Alliances and Coalitions

5.1 The Lublin Triangle: Poland, Ukraine, Lithuania

Among the most consequential diplomatic innovations to emerge from the transformed security environment of Central and Eastern Europe is the Lublin Triangle—a trilateral cooperation format uniting Poland, Lithuania, and Ukraine. Established on July 28, 2020, during a ministerial meeting in the historic Polish city of Lublin, the format initially attracted relatively limited international attention, perceived by many observers as one of numerous multilateral groupings in a region already saturated with overlapping cooperative frameworks. The full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine transformed the Lublin Triangle from a diplomatic curiosity into one of the most operationally significant regional formats in contemporary European politics.

The historical resonance of the Lublin Triangle is profound and deliberate. The city of Lublin was the site of the 1569 Union of Lublin, which created the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth—one of the largest and most influential political entities in early modern European history, and a polity that encompassed substantial portions of what is now Ukraine. The invocation of this historical precedent was not merely decorative; it reflected a conscious effort by the three participating states to ground their contemporary cooperation in a shared historical narrative of political association, cultural exchange, and common resistance to external domination—specifically, to the imperial ambitions of Moscow, which had been a defining feature of the region’s geopolitics for centuries.

The operational significance of the Lublin Triangle after February 2022 derived from the complementary capabilities and strategic positions of its three members. Poland provided the logistical depth, military capability, and diplomatic weight necessary to serve as the primary conduit for Western military assistance to Ukraine. Lithuania contributed its deep expertise in hybrid warfare, strategic communications, and the specific challenge of managing security threats from Russia and Belarus. Ukraine, as the state directly engaged in combat with Russian forces, provided the immediate operational context and the urgent strategic requirements that gave the format its purpose and its focus.

The three states coordinated closely on a range of practical matters, from the facilitation of weapons transfers and the training of Ukrainian military personnel to the coordination of diplomatic messaging and the development of common positions in NATO and EU forums. The Lublin Triangle also served as a platform for advocating Ukrainian membership in both NATO and the European Union, with Poland and Lithuania consistently among the most vocal supporters of Ukrainian accession within both institutions.

The format’s significance extended beyond its immediate operational utility. It represented a model of regional cooperation driven by shared threat perception and common strategic interest rather than by the bureaucratic imperatives of existing institutional frameworks. The Lublin Triangle demonstrated that effective multilateral cooperation in the security domain could emerge organically from the strategic needs of frontline states, without requiring the elaborate institutional architecture and consensus mechanisms that characterized larger organizations like NATO and the EU. This model of flexible, purpose-driven cooperation has attracted interest from other states in the region and may prove influential in shaping future patterns of regional security cooperation.

The Lublin Triangle is not without its limitations and vulnerabilities. The format’s effectiveness depends critically on the continued alignment of its three members’ strategic

interests, and the domestic political dynamics of each state introduce elements of uncertainty. Poland's internal political transitions—from the Law and Justice government to the Civic Coalition government led by Donald Tusk following the October 2023 elections—altered the tone but not the fundamental direction of Polish engagement in the format. The periodic tensions between Warsaw and Kyiv over agricultural trade, historical memory, and other bilateral irritants have the potential to strain the trilateral relationship, though thus far these tensions have been managed without fundamentally undermining the format's operational effectiveness.

5.2 The Three Seas Initiative: New Momentum

The Three Seas Initiative (TSI), formally established in 2016 as a platform for cooperation among the twelve EU member states situated between the Baltic, Black, and Adriatic Seas, experienced a significant revitalization in the aftermath of Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Originally conceived as a framework for promoting infrastructure, energy, and digital connectivity along the north-south axis of Central and Eastern Europe—an axis historically neglected in favor of the east-west corridors that connected the region to Russia and Western Europe—the Three Seas Initiative acquired new strategic relevance in a security environment that placed an enormous premium on precisely the kind of infrastructure and energy diversification that the initiative was designed to promote.

The logic of the Three Seas Initiative is fundamentally geographic and infrastructural. The infrastructure networks of Central and Eastern Europe were constructed during the 19th and 20th centuries primarily along east-west axes, connecting the region's economies to the imperial centers of Berlin, Vienna, and Moscow. North-south connections—linking the Baltic states to Poland, Poland to Romania, Romania to Greece—were historically underdeveloped, leaving the region's economies poorly connected to one another and excessively dependent on transit routes and supply chains running through or from Russia. The Three Seas Initiative's central objective was to correct this structural imbalance by promoting investment in north-south transport corridors, energy interconnectors, and digital infrastructure.

The invasion of Ukraine dramatically accelerated the relevance and urgency of this agenda. The need to transport military equipment and humanitarian supplies from Baltic and North Sea ports to Ukraine's western border placed immediate demands on north-south transport infrastructure. The need to diversify energy supplies away from Russian sources required precisely the kind of LNG terminals, gas interconnectors, and electricity grid upgrades that the Three Seas Initiative had been advocating. The Via Carpatia highway project,

connecting Lithuania through Poland, Slovakia, Hungary, and Romania to Greece, acquired new strategic significance as both a civilian transport corridor and a potential military logistics route—the kind of dual-use infrastructure investment that epitomizes the blurring of economic and security considerations in the post-invasion environment.

The Three Seas Investment Fund, established to mobilize public and private capital for infrastructure projects within the initiative's member states, received additional commitments from participating governments and attracted growing interest from external partners, notably the United States. American support for the Three Seas Initiative, which had been expressed at the presidential level since the 2017 Warsaw Summit, was reinforced in the post-invasion period as Washington recognized the initiative's alignment with its own strategic objectives of reducing European dependence on Russian energy, strengthening the economic resilience of NATO's eastern members, and providing alternative investment frameworks to Chinese infrastructure financing through the Belt and Road Initiative.

The initiative's membership—Austria, Bulgaria, Croatia, the Czech Republic, Estonia, Hungary, Greece, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, Romania, Slovakia, and Slovenia—encompasses a geographically contiguous bloc of EU member states with a combined population exceeding 110 million and a combined GDP approaching \$2 trillion. The inclusion of both "frontline" states like Poland and the Baltics and more ambivalently positioned states like Hungary and Austria creates internal tensions that mirror the broader divisions within CEE on questions of Russia policy. Nevertheless, the initiative's focus on concrete infrastructure and economic projects provides a basis for cooperation that can, at least partially, transcend the political disagreements that divide its members on more contentious geopolitical questions.

The Three Seas Initiative's relationship with the European Union's broader infrastructure and energy policies has been a persistent source of discussion. Some Western European commentators have viewed the initiative with suspicion, interpreting it as an attempt to create a competing institutional framework that might fragment EU cohesion or serve as a vehicle for American influence within the Union. The initiative's proponents have consistently rejected this characterization, arguing that the TSI complements rather than competes with EU policies and that its focus on addressing a genuine infrastructure deficit within the Union serves the interests of European cohesion rather than undermining them.

5.3 The Visegrad Group in Crisis

If the Lublin Triangle and the Three Seas Initiative represent the emerging architecture of regional cooperation in Central and Eastern Europe, the Visegrad Group (V4) represents the

institutional casualty of the post-invasion realignment. Established in 1991 as a platform for coordinating the Euro-Atlantic integration strategies of Poland, Hungary, the Czech Republic, and Slovakia, the V4 had served for three decades as one of the most recognizable and frequently cited examples of successful post-Cold War regional cooperation. The Russian invasion of Ukraine exposed and deepened fault lines within the group that had been accumulating for years, raising fundamental questions about whether the format retains any meaningful strategic purpose.

The V4's crisis is fundamentally a crisis of divergent threat perceptions and strategic orientations. Poland and the Czech Republic responded to the invasion with unambiguous solidarity with Ukraine, providing substantial military assistance, hosting large refugee populations, and advocating forcefully within NATO and the EU for the strongest possible response to Russian aggression. Hungary and Slovakia, as discussed in previous sections, adopted positions that ranged from ambivalent to obstructive, maintaining energy relationships with Russia, blocking or delaying collective Western measures, and articulating public positions on the conflict that aligned more closely with Russian narratives than with the consensus of their Alliance and Union partners.

The divergence within the V4 was not a sudden development but the culmination of a longer process of strategic drift. Throughout the preceding decade, the V4 had been increasingly characterized by the tension between its two internal blocs: a Polish-Czech orientation toward transatlanticism, robust deterrence, and principled support for the democratic aspirations of Eastern European states, and a Hungarian-Slovak orientation toward pragmatic engagement with Russia, skepticism of EU institutional constraints, and a more transactional approach to foreign policy. The invasion simply made this tension impossible to ignore or to paper over with diplomatic formulas.

The practical consequences of the V4's dysfunction have been significant. The group has been unable to produce common positions on major questions of European security and has effectively ceased to function as a coordinating mechanism for its members' policies in NATO and the EU. Joint V4 summit meetings, once regular features of the regional diplomatic calendar, have become infrequent and largely ceremonial. The format's institutional infrastructure—the International Visegrad Fund and various sectoral cooperation programs—continues to operate but without the strategic direction that active political engagement from all four member governments would provide.

The question of whether the V4 can be rehabilitated or whether it should be acknowledged as a spent force has generated considerable debate among analysts and

policymakers in the region. Some argue that the format retains latent value as a platform for sectoral cooperation—in areas such as transport infrastructure, digital connectivity, and cultural exchange—even if its capacity for strategic coordination has been effectively destroyed. Others contend that the resources and political capital invested in maintaining the fiction of V4 cohesion would be better directed toward formats that reflect the actual strategic alignments of the post-invasion period.

Poland's position is particularly consequential for the V4's future. As the group's largest and most powerful member, Poland's engagement is essential to the format's relevance, and Warsaw's growing frustration with Hungarian and Slovak positions has led to a visible deprioritization of the V4 in Polish diplomatic strategy. The Polish government's increasing investment in alternative formats—the Lublin Triangle, the Three Seas Initiative, bilateral relationships with the Baltic states and Romania, and the broader "coalition of the willing" supporting Ukraine—reflects a practical assessment that the V4 no longer serves Poland's core strategic interests.

5.4 The "Coalition of the Willing" and CEE's Leading Role

Beyond the formal institutional frameworks discussed above, the post-invasion period has seen the emergence of informal coalitions that have proven remarkably effective in shaping the Western response to Russian aggression. These "coalitions of the willing"—loose groupings of states united by common strategic assessment and shared willingness to act—have often been driven by CEE states that have leveraged their frontline position, their intimate knowledge of the threat, and their demonstrated commitment to Ukrainian defense to exercise influence disproportionate to their formal diplomatic weight.

The most prominent manifestation of this coalition-building has been in the domain of military assistance to Ukraine. From the earliest days of the conflict, a core group of states—including Poland, the Baltic states, the Czech Republic, the United Kingdom, and the Nordic countries—established themselves as the most reliable and forthcoming providers of military support. This group consistently pushed for the provision of increasingly capable weapons systems, often overcoming the hesitations of larger Alliance members through a combination of diplomatic advocacy, practical demonstration, and the simple expedient of acting first and inviting others to follow. The pattern was repeated across multiple categories of military assistance: Soviet-era tanks and infantry fighting vehicles were provided by Poland and the Czech Republic; air defense systems by the Baltic states and Germany; long-range missiles by

the United Kingdom and France; and eventually main battle tanks and fighter aircraft by broader coalitions assembled through persistent advocacy.

The CEE states' leading role in these coalitions reflected not only their geographic proximity and strategic urgency but also a distinctive approach to alliance politics—one that prioritized practical action over institutional consensus-building and that was willing to accept bilateral risks in pursuit of collective objectives. This approach sometimes generated friction with larger Alliance members who preferred a more deliberate and coordinated process, but it repeatedly proved effective in shifting the boundaries of what was considered politically feasible and in creating momentum for decisions that might otherwise have been delayed or avoided.

The informal coalition dynamics of the post-invasion period have also extended to the diplomatic domain. The CEE states have coordinated their advocacy for Ukrainian EU and NATO membership, for the maintenance and strengthening of sanctions against Russia, and for the development of long-term security commitments to Ukraine through a combination of formal diplomatic channels and informal networking that has proven more agile and responsive than the consensus-based decision-making processes of larger institutions.

5.5 CEE and the Western Balkans: New Dynamics

The Russian invasion of Ukraine has significantly altered the dynamics of Central and Eastern Europe's relationship with the Western Balkans—a region that, while geographically adjacent and historically intertwined, has occupied a distinct position in European strategic thinking. The invasion has affected the Western Balkans through multiple channels: by reshaping the geopolitical context of the region's EU accession process, by exposing the vulnerabilities created by Russian and Chinese influence in the region, and by generating new pressures and opportunities for states seeking to navigate between competing great power interests.

Serbia's position has attracted the most intense scrutiny. Belgrade has maintained a complex balancing act between its EU accession aspirations and its historically close relationship with Russia, declining to join EU sanctions against Moscow while continuing to participate in EU-facilitated dialogue with Kosovo. President Aleksandar Vučić has sought to present this balancing act as a defense of Serbian sovereignty and national interest, but the contradiction between Serbia's stated aspiration for EU membership and its refusal to align with EU foreign policy on the most consequential security issue facing the continent has generated increasing impatience in Brussels and in CEE capitals.

For the CEE states, the Serbian case illustrates a broader dilemma in their approach to the Western Balkans. On one hand, the CEE states—particularly those with recent memories of their own accession processes—are generally supportive of Western Balkan EU enlargement, recognizing that the integration of the region is essential for European security and stability. On the other hand, the tolerance for strategic ambiguity that characterized the pre-invasion approach to the Western Balkans has diminished significantly. The CEE states, having themselves made definitive strategic choices in favor of Euro-Atlantic integration, have limited patience for Western Balkan governments that seek to maintain equidistance between the West and Russia or China.

Bosnia and Herzegovina's granting of EU candidate status in December 2022, Kosovo's application for EU membership in December 2022, and the broader revitalization of the enlargement agenda reflect a recognition that the geopolitical competition for influence in the Western Balkans has intensified and that the EU's failure to deliver on its enlargement promises risks creating a strategic vacuum that Russia, China, and other actors will fill. The CEE states have been among the most consistent advocates for accelerating the enlargement process, drawing on their own experience to argue that the prospect of EU membership—however distant—provides the most effective incentive structure for the political and economic reforms that the Western Balkan states urgently need.

5.6 The Global South and CEE: Competing Narratives

The international diplomatic landscape that emerged from the Russian invasion of Ukraine was characterized not only by the sharp divisions between Russia and the West but also by the more complex and often ambivalent positioning of the Global South—the large bloc of states in Africa, Asia, Latin America, and the Middle East that declined to align fully with either side in the conflict. For the states of Central and Eastern Europe, the attitudes of the Global South represented both a diplomatic challenge and an opportunity for strategic communication.

The narrative contest between Russia and the West for the sympathies of the Global South touched directly on issues of deep concern to CEE states. Russia's framing of the conflict as a struggle against Western hegemony and NATO expansion resonated with states that had their own historical grievances against Western power and that were wary of being drawn into what they perceived as a European conflict with no direct bearing on their interests. The Western counter-narrative—emphasizing the defense of sovereignty, territorial integrity, and the rules-based international order—aligned more closely with the normative framework that the

United Nations system ostensibly upheld but was complicated by historical inconsistencies in Western adherence to these principles.

For CEE states, the engagement with Global South narratives required a degree of diplomatic sophistication that was not always naturally available to governments whose foreign policy establishments had been primarily focused on European and transatlantic affairs. The Baltic states and Poland, in particular, made efforts to communicate their own historical experiences of imperial domination and resistance as a basis for solidarity with post-colonial states. The argument that small states had a shared interest in defending the principle of sovereignty against the predations of larger powers had considerable logical force, though its effectiveness in overcoming the historical skepticism of many Global South states toward European powers remained uneven.

The UN General Assembly votes on resolutions related to the invasion provided a quantitative measure of the international community's divisions. While the initial resolution condemning the invasion received overwhelming support—141 votes in favor—subsequent resolutions showed modest erosion in this majority, and the persistent bloc of abstentions demonstrated the limits of Western diplomatic influence in regions where economic ties with Russia and China, resentment of perceived Western double standards, and pragmatic calculations of national interest outweighed sympathy for Ukraine's plight. The CEE states' contribution to maintaining and strengthening this majority, through bilateral diplomatic outreach, participation in multilateral forums, and practical engagement with the concerns of Global South states—particularly regarding food and energy security—represented a significant and ongoing dimension of the region's diplomatic evolution.

The intersection of the Global South debate with the internal politics of the European Union also carried implications for CEE. The EU's aspiration to position itself as a credible interlocutor with the Global South on issues ranging from climate change to trade policy required a degree of internal coherence that the divisions within CEE—particularly Hungary's dissent—complicated. The CEE states that were most active in supporting Ukraine also tended to be those most engaged in building relationships with Global South partners, recognizing that the long-term sustainability of Ukraine's international support depended on maintaining the broadest possible coalition beyond the transatlantic core.

Chapter 6. The Democratic Dimension – Freedom, Sovereignty and the Tocquevillian Lens

6.1 Tocqueville's Framework Applied to CEE

Alexis de Tocqueville's enduring relevance to the study of modern democracy lies not in the specificity of his observations about Jacksonian America but in the universality of the analytical categories he developed to understand the relationship between liberty, equality, and political power. His central preoccupations—the conditions under which democratic self-government can flourish, the dangers that threaten it from within and without, and the role of civic associations and local institutions in sustaining the democratic fabric—are startlingly applicable to the contemporary situation of Central and Eastern Europe, a region in which the meaning and practice of democracy have been violently contested by Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

Tocqueville's concept of the "tyranny of the majority" offers a particularly fertile analytical framework for understanding the geopolitical dynamics of the CEE region. In its original formulation, the concept described the danger that democratic majorities might use their numerical superiority to suppress the rights and interests of minorities, creating a form of oppression that was all the more insidious for being clothed in the legitimacy of popular sovereignty. Applied to the international system, the concept illuminates the structural vulnerability of small and medium-sized states in a world where great powers—claiming the legitimacy of their own strategic interests, historical narratives, or civilizational missions—seek to impose their will on weaker neighbors.

Russia's invasion of Ukraine represents, in this Tocquevillian framework, the ultimate expression of geopolitical "tyranny of the majority"—the assertion by a larger and more powerful state that its interests, its historical narratives, and its conception of regional order take precedence over the sovereign choices of a smaller neighbor. Putin's denial of Ukrainian statehood, his characterization of Ukrainian national identity as an artificial construction, and his insistence that Ukraine's foreign policy orientation is a matter of Russian rather than Ukrainian decision-making all constitute variations on the theme that Tocqueville identified: the subjugation of individual (in this case, national) liberty to the preferences of a dominant power that claims to represent a larger collective interest.

For the states of Central and Eastern Europe, this dynamic is not an abstraction but a lived historical experience. The nations of the region have spent centuries navigating the competing imperial ambitions of Russia, Germany, Austria-Hungary, and the Ottoman Empire, and their collective memory is saturated with the experience of having their sovereignty, their institutions, and their cultural identities subordinated to the strategic calculations of larger powers. The Yalta Conference of 1945, at which the postwar division of Europe was negotiated

among the great powers without meaningful consultation of the nations most directly affected, remains a powerful symbol of this experience—one that continues to shape the strategic culture and diplomatic reflexes of CEE states to this day.

Tocqueville's analysis also highlighted the countervailing forces that could resist the tyranny of the majority: the vitality of local institutions, the strength of civic associations, the independence of the judiciary, and the moral commitment of citizens to the principles of liberty and self-government. These countervailing forces are precisely what have been at stake in the post-invasion period—both within Ukraine, where democratic institutions have been tested by the existential pressures of total war, and within the broader CEE region, where the commitment to democratic governance has been challenged by populist movements, authoritarian temptations, and the seductive logic of security-driven centralization.

6.2 Sovereignty as the Central Value of CEE's International Relations

The concept of sovereignty occupies a position of unparalleled centrality in the political discourse and strategic culture of Central and Eastern Europe. This centrality is not a matter of abstract philosophical commitment but a reflection of concrete historical experience—the experience of nations that have repeatedly lost their sovereignty, had it restored, and lived in constant awareness of its fragility. For the states of the region, sovereignty is not one value among many in the hierarchy of international relations; it is the foundational condition without which all other values—democracy, human rights, economic prosperity, cultural identity—become meaningless abstractions.

The historical depth of this conviction cannot be overstated. Poland disappeared from the map of Europe for 123 years following the Third Partition in 1795, its territory divided among Russia, Prussia, and Austria. The Baltic states enjoyed barely two decades of independence between the world wars before being absorbed into the Soviet Union in 1940—an incorporation that the Western democracies refused to recognize *de jure* but were powerless to reverse *de facto*. Hungary experienced the trauma of the Treaty of Trianon in 1920, which reduced its territory by two-thirds, and the subsequent Soviet invasion of 1956, which crushed its attempt to achieve genuine self-determination. Czechoslovakia was dismembered by the Munich Agreement of 1938 and invaded by Warsaw Pact forces in 1968. Ukraine's entire modern history has been shaped by the struggle for sovereignty—from the brief and unsuccessful attempt to establish an independent state in 1918–1921, through the Soviet period, to the hard-won independence of 1991 and the ongoing war to defend it.

These experiences have produced a strategic culture in which sovereignty is understood not as a given but as an achievement—one that must be actively defended against the persistent ambitions of larger powers. The Russian invasion of Ukraine has reinforced this understanding with unprecedented force, demonstrating that the threat to sovereignty is not a relic of the 19th or 20th centuries but a present and immediate reality. For CEE states, the lesson of February 2022 is unambiguous: sovereignty cannot be secured through declarations, treaties, or international norms alone; it requires the material capacity—military, economic, and diplomatic—to defend it, and the collective commitment of allies willing to share the burden of its defense.

The sovereignty-centered worldview of CEE has significant implications for the region's approach to European integration. Unlike some Western European perspectives that view sovereignty as a resource to be pooled and shared within supranational institutions, the CEE perspective tends to regard sovereignty as an irreducible national attribute that can be exercised through—but never fully delegated to—multilateral organizations. This does not imply opposition to European integration; on the contrary, most CEE states view EU and NATO membership as essential instruments for the protection and exercise of sovereignty rather than as limitations upon it. The distinction is subtle but consequential: for the CEE states, membership in Western institutions is a strategic choice made by sovereign nations to enhance their security and prosperity, not a subordination of national sovereignty to supranational authority.

This perspective has shaped the CEE states' approach to the question of Ukrainian EU and NATO membership. The argument from Warsaw, Tallinn, and Vilnius is not primarily framed in terms of European values or institutional expansion but in terms of sovereign choice: Ukraine has the sovereign right to choose its own foreign policy orientation, and the denial of this right by Russia constitutes an assault on the foundational principles of the international order. The defense of Ukrainian sovereignty is, from this perspective, not merely an act of solidarity but a defense of the principle upon which the sovereignty of all states in the region ultimately depends.

6.3 Democracy Under Pressure: Internal Challenges

The external threat to democracy posed by Russian aggression has coincided with significant internal challenges to democratic governance within Central and Eastern Europe—challenges that complicate the region's narrative of democratic solidarity and that raise

uncomfortable questions about the depth and resilience of democratic institutions in states that transitioned from authoritarianism barely three decades ago.

Hungary's trajectory under Viktor Orbán represents the most extensively documented and analytically contentious case of democratic regression within the EU. The systematic weakening of judicial independence, the concentration of media ownership in the hands of government-aligned oligarchs, the manipulation of electoral rules to entrench ruling party advantages, and the use of state resources for partisan purposes have led the European Parliament to declare, in a 2022 resolution, that Hungary can "no longer be considered a full democracy" and should instead be characterized as "a hybrid regime of electoral autocracy." The European Commission's activation of the conditionality mechanism—linking EU funding to compliance with rule of law standards—represented an unprecedented institutional response to democratic backsliding within the Union.

The Hungarian case is particularly troubling in the context of the post-invasion environment because it demonstrates that the external threat of Russian aggression does not automatically strengthen democratic institutions within the states that face that threat. Orbán has skillfully exploited the war as a pretext for further concentration of power, using emergency measures and nationalist rhetoric to marginalize opposition voices and to characterize criticism of his government's Russia-friendly foreign policy as unpatriotic disloyalty. The paradox is striking: a state that owes its sovereignty and independence to the collapse of Soviet authoritarianism has developed a governance model that draws explicit inspiration from what Orbán himself has described as "illiberal democracy"—a concept that Tocqueville would have recognized as an oxymoron fundamentally incompatible with genuine self-government.

Poland's democratic trajectory has been more complex and ultimately more encouraging. The Law and Justice government's conflicts with the European Commission over judicial independence and media freedom generated genuine concern about democratic backsliding, and the parallels with Hungary's trajectory were frequently and not unreasonably drawn. However, the October 2023 parliamentary elections demonstrated the resilience of Polish democratic institutions and civil society, producing a transfer of power to the opposition Civic Coalition led by Donald Tusk—a transition that was accomplished through free and fair elections, despite significant institutional advantages enjoyed by the incumbent government. The Polish case suggests that democratic backsliding is not irreversible and that the vitality of civil society, the independence of electoral institutions, and the engagement of citizens in the democratic process can produce self-correcting mechanisms capable of restoring democratic norms.

The broader pattern across CEE is one of democratic unevenness rather than uniform regression or uniform consolidation. The Czech Republic has maintained a robust democratic system throughout the post-invasion period, with competitive elections, independent media, and effective institutional checks on executive power. The Baltic states have similarly demonstrated the strength of their democratic institutions, though concerns about the civic integration of Russian-speaking minorities—particularly in Estonia and Latvia—remain a potential vulnerability that Russian influence operations have consistently sought to exploit. Romania and Bulgaria have struggled with corruption and institutional weakness, though both have maintained the fundamental framework of democratic governance and have shown gradual improvement in areas such as judicial independence and media freedom.

The challenge for CEE’s democratic development in the post-invasion period is the tension between the legitimate security imperatives of wartime and the preservation of the democratic freedoms that the war is ostensibly being fought to defend. The expansion of surveillance capabilities, the restriction of information in the name of national security, the centralization of decision-making authority in executive branches, and the reduction of space for political dissent—all of which are temptations during periods of heightened security threat—carry the risk of eroding the democratic substance of states whose democratic traditions are still relatively young and whose institutional safeguards against authoritarian regression are still being tested.

6.4 Civil Society and Democratic Resilience

If the internal challenges to democracy in CEE represent the Tocquevillian dangers that the region faces, the remarkable mobilization of civil society in response to the invasion of Ukraine represents the Tocquevillian remedy. Tocqueville regarded the vitality of civic associations—voluntary organizations, community groups, religious institutions, and other forms of collective self-organization—as the essential foundation of democratic life, the mechanism through which citizens developed the habits of cooperation, mutual responsibility, and public engagement that sustained democratic institutions against the centralizing tendencies of state power.

The civil society response to the Ukrainian refugee crisis across Central and Eastern Europe was extraordinary in its scale, its spontaneity, and its organizational sophistication. In Poland, ordinary citizens organized reception centers at border crossings, offered accommodation in private homes, provided transportation and translation services, and created informal networks for the distribution of food, clothing, and medical supplies—all before state

institutions had fully mobilized their resources. Similar patterns of grassroots mobilization were observed in the Czech Republic, Romania, Slovakia, and the Baltic states, where civil society organizations and individual volunteers supplemented and in many cases preceded the official governmental response.

The scale of this mobilization was remarkable by any historical standard. In the first months of the conflict, Poland absorbed over three million Ukrainian refugees—the largest refugee movement in Europe since the Second World War—with a degree of social solidarity that confounded the predictions of analysts who had expected the kind of anti-refugee backlash that had characterized responses to the 2015 migration crisis. The difference in public response—welcoming Ukrainian refugees while resisting the admission of migrants from the Middle East and North Africa—raised legitimate questions about the role of cultural proximity, ethnic similarity, and religious identity in shaping solidarity, but the practical achievement of absorbing such an enormous population movement without significant social disruption was nonetheless extraordinary.

The volunteer networks that emerged during the crisis demonstrated the capacity of CEE civil societies to self-organize in response to collective challenges—precisely the capacity that Tocqueville had identified as the foundation of democratic resilience. These networks were not directed from above by governmental authorities or established institutional hierarchies; they emerged organically from the spontaneous decisions of individual citizens to contribute to a collective effort. The experience strengthened civic bonds, created new forms of social capital, and demonstrated to citizens their own capacity for effective collective action—all of which constitute the building blocks of a healthy democratic culture.

Non-governmental organizations played a critical role in supplementing the civil society response, providing professional expertise, institutional capacity, and international connections that grassroots volunteer networks often lacked. Organizations such as the Polish Center for International Aid, the Czech organization People in Need, and numerous smaller local and national NGOs throughout the region served as intermediaries between international donors, governmental agencies, and the communities most directly affected by the refugee influx. The Ukrainian civil society organizations that continued to operate despite the war—coordinating humanitarian assistance, documenting human rights violations, and maintaining the fabric of democratic governance under extraordinary conditions—provided inspiration and practical partnership for their CEE counterparts.

The media landscape of CEE also demonstrated elements of democratic resilience, though with significant caveats. Independent media outlets in the region provided essential

coverage of the conflict, challenged governmental narratives where appropriate, and contributed to the informed public discourse that democratic decision-making requires. However, the media environment was also characterized by significant vulnerabilities: the concentration of media ownership in some states, the penetration of Russian disinformation through social media and fringe outlets, and the challenge of maintaining journalistic independence in an environment of heightened national security sensitivity all posed ongoing threats to the quality and pluralism of public information.

6.5 The Future of Liberal Democracy in CEE After the War

The question of what the Russian invasion of Ukraine ultimately means for the future of liberal democracy in Central and Eastern Europe admits no definitive answer at this stage of the conflict—but the evidence accumulated thus far permits certain provisional observations that may prove useful for understanding the trajectory of democratic development in the region.

The first observation is that the war has, on balance, strengthened rather than weakened the democratic commitment of the CEE societies most directly affected by it. The experience of confronting an existential threat from an authoritarian adversary has reinforced the association between democratic self-government and national survival, creating a powerful narrative that links the defense of sovereignty to the defense of democratic values. In Poland, the democratic transfer of power in 2023 demonstrated that the institutions of democracy can function effectively even under conditions of heightened security threat. In the Baltic states, the continued vitality of democratic governance—including robust debate about the appropriate response to the Russian threat—has demonstrated that security and liberty are not mutually exclusive values.

The second observation is that the war has exposed the vulnerability of democratic institutions to authoritarian subversion from both without and within. Russia's use of disinformation, political influence operations, energy coercion, and the exploitation of internal divisions within democratic societies represents a comprehensive challenge to democratic governance that extends far beyond the immediate military dimensions of the conflict. The Hungarian case demonstrates that authoritarian tendencies within a democratic polity can exploit external threats to accelerate the concentration of power and the erosion of institutional safeguards.

The third observation is that the long-term health of democracy in CEE will depend on the resolution of tensions that the war has highlighted but not resolved. The tension between security imperatives and civil liberties, between national sovereignty and supranational

cooperation, between ethnic solidarity and universal human rights, and between the economic costs of confronting aggression and the political sustainability of policies that impose those costs on citizens—these tensions will continue to shape the democratic trajectory of the region regardless of the conflict's military outcome.

Tocqueville himself recognized that democracy is never a settled condition but an ongoing project—a continuous negotiation between the aspirations of liberty and equality, the pressures of power and interest, and the ever-present temptation to sacrifice long-term institutional health for short-term political advantage. The states of Central and Eastern Europe are engaged in precisely this negotiation, under conditions of extraordinary pressure and with stakes that extend far beyond their own borders. The outcome will be determined not by the grand strategies of governments and alliances alone but by the cumulative choices of citizens, communities, and civil society organizations—the "associations" that Tocqueville identified as the true foundation of democratic life.

The war has provided, paradoxically, both the greatest threat and the greatest stimulus to democratic development in CEE. The threat is obvious: authoritarian aggression, democratic backsliding, the erosion of institutional norms, and the seductive logic of security-driven centralization. The stimulus is equally real: the mobilization of civil society, the strengthening of democratic commitment through existential challenge, the demonstration that democratic societies are capable of extraordinary collective action in defense of their values, and the recognition that the defense of democracy at home and the defense of democracy abroad are ultimately the same struggle.

Whether the stimulus will prove stronger than the threat remains to be seen. But the evidence of the post-invasion period suggests grounds for cautious optimism—not the naive optimism of the "End of History" but the more grounded and more resilient optimism of societies that have learned, through bitter experience, the value of the democratic institutions they possess and the costs of failing to defend them.

Conclusion

Synthesis and Final Reflections

The preceding analysis has traced the contours of a transformation that is simultaneously military and diplomatic, economic and cultural, institutional and deeply personal—a transformation that the full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine initiated but that the societies, governments, and institutions of Central and Eastern Europe are actively shaping through their responses. The central argument of this study—that Russia’s invasion has acted as a catalyst for the comprehensive restructuring of diplomatic, security, and economic relations in CEE, producing a fundamentally altered regional order—has been substantiated across multiple dimensions of analysis.

The pre-war order, as the first section demonstrated, was not the stable equilibrium that many Western observers had assumed but a system of accumulated contradictions held together by economic interdependence, strategic complacency, and a willful refusal to take seriously the warnings of the states most directly exposed to Russian pressure. The post-Cold War settlement’s fundamental assumptions—that economic integration would pacify Russian behavior, that symbolic military deterrence was sufficient to protect exposed Alliance members, and that the security concerns of small frontline states could be safely subordinated to the imperatives of managing the relationship with Moscow—were not merely mistaken but dangerously so, in ways that the invasion has made unmistakably clear.

The diplomatic realignment documented in the second section represents one of the most significant reorderings of regional influence in post-Cold War European history. Poland and the Baltic states have emerged from the margins of European strategic decision-making to occupy a central position in the definition of Alliance and Union policy toward Russia and Ukraine. The credibility conferred by decades of accurate threat assessment and by the practical commitment demonstrated through the provision of military assistance has given these states an influence in NATO and EU councils that bears no relationship to their formal demographic or economic weight. Conversely, the dissenting positions of Hungary and Slovakia have demonstrated the limits of internal Alliance cohesion and have raised fundamental questions about the mechanisms available to democratic alliances for managing members whose governments align more closely with adversarial powers than with Alliance partners.

The security architecture examined in the third section has undergone changes that would have seemed inconceivable a decade ago. The transformation of NATO’s Enhanced Forward Presence from a symbolic tripwire into a genuinely combat-capable defensive posture,

the accession of Finland and Sweden and the consequent transformation of the Baltic Sea into a NATO lake, the revolution in military spending across the region, and the fundamental revision of Alliance strategic planning all represent permanent structural changes whose implications will shape European security for a generation. The question of Ukrainian NATO membership—unresolved at the time of writing—remains the central unfinished business of the Alliance’s eastern transformation, and its ultimate resolution will be decisive for the long-term stability of the emerging regional order.

The economic consequences analyzed in the fourth section demonstrate that the restructuring of CEE is not confined to the political and military domains but extends to the fundamental organization of the region’s economic relationships. The decoupling from Russian energy, the expansion of defense industries, the integration of the Ukrainian economy, and the reorientation of trade and investment toward alternative partners have collectively produced an economic realignment that is likely to prove durable and that will continue to generate second and third-order consequences for years to come. The painful costs of this realignment—inflation, trade disruption, fiscal pressure—have been absorbed by CEE populations with a degree of solidarity that reflects the genuine depth of the region’s commitment to the values at stake, though the long-term sustainability of this solidarity cannot be guaranteed against the pressures of economic hardship and political opportunism.

The new alliances and coalitions examined in the fifth section reveal a regional architecture in formation—one that is replacing the Cold War’s imposed divisions with new patterns of association driven by shared strategic interests, common threat perceptions, and complementary capabilities. The Lublin Triangle, the Three Seas Initiative, and the informal coalitions of willing states supporting Ukraine represent experiments in a new form of regional agency that is more flexible, more purpose-driven, and more responsive to the actual security environment than the more rigid institutional frameworks of the preceding era. The crisis of the Visegrad Group, while representing a genuine institutional failure, also demonstrates the self-correcting capacity of regional diplomacy to abandon formats that no longer serve their original purpose and to develop new ones better suited to changed circumstances.

The democratic dimension explored in the sixth section places all of the preceding analysis in its deepest context—the contest between democratic self-government and authoritarian power that Alexis de Tocqueville identified as the defining challenge of modern political life. The Tocquevillian framework illuminates both the nature of the threat facing CEE—a geopolitical "tyranny of the majority" in which a larger power seeks to deny smaller neighbors the right of sovereign self-determination—and the resources available to resist it: the

vitality of civil society, the commitment of citizens to democratic values, and the institutional capacity of democratic states to coordinate effective collective action.

Research Question Revisited

Returning to the central research question—to what extent has Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine restructured the diplomatic, security, and economic relations of CEE states, and what are the characteristics of the emerging regional order?—the evidence presented in this study supports a clear and unambiguous answer: the restructuring has been profound, multidimensional, and largely irreversible in its most fundamental aspects.

The emerging regional order in CEE is characterized by several defining features. First, it is an order in which the frontline states—Poland, the Baltic states, and Romania—exercise strategic leadership disproportionate to their formal weight, driven by the credibility conferred by accurate threat assessment and demonstrated commitment. Second, it is an order in which the distinction between economic and security policy has been effectively erased, with energy infrastructure, trade relationships, and industrial capacity all understood as dimensions of strategic competition rather than purely commercial considerations. Third, it is an order characterized by greater internal differentiation than the post-Cold War period, with the divergence between states committed to the Euro-Atlantic consensus and states pursuing more ambivalent relationships with Russia creating a new internal fault line that is likely to persist and to complicate regional cooperation. Fourth, and perhaps most consequentially, it is an order in which the question of Ukrainian integration into Euro-Atlantic institutions has moved from the theoretical to the operational agenda, making the eventual resolution of this question the central determinant of the region’s long-term security architecture.

Limitations of the Study

This research necessarily reflects the limitations of analyzing a dynamic and rapidly evolving situation from a temporal vantage point at which many of the processes described remain incomplete. The war in Ukraine continues at the time of writing, and its military, political, and economic trajectory will substantially shape the ultimate form of the regional order that this study has attempted to characterize. The conclusions drawn here are therefore provisional in important respects—robust with regard to the direction and magnitude of the structural changes underway but necessarily uncertain with regard to their ultimate configuration.

The study's reliance on publicly available sources—government statements, think tank analyses, journalistic reporting, and academic publications—introduces the limitations characteristic of research conducted without access to classified intelligence assessments or internal governmental deliberations. The diplomatic processes of NATO and the European Union are conducted primarily behind closed doors, and the public record provides only a partial and sometimes misleading picture of the actual dynamics of Alliance decision-making. Future research drawing on declassified documents and participant interviews will undoubtedly produce a more nuanced and complete account of the events analyzed here.

Directions for Future Research

Several dimensions of the transformation analyzed in this study merit more detailed and sustained scholarly attention than has been possible within the scope of a single paper. The comparative analysis of CEE states' domestic political responses to the invasion—the ways in which the war has shaped electoral politics, party systems, and public opinion in different national contexts—represents a rich field for political science research. The economic consequences of the defense spending revolution across the region, including its implications for fiscal sustainability, industrial policy, and the political economy of security, constitute an important agenda for economic research. The long-term social and cultural consequences of mass Ukrainian migration into CEE societies—the transformation of national identities, cultural landscapes, and social structures produced by the integration of millions of Ukrainian refugees—represent a major theme for sociological and anthropological inquiry.

Most urgently, the question of Ukrainian EU and NATO membership—its conditions, timeline, institutional implications, and consequences for the regional order—demands sustained analytical attention from scholars capable of bridging the disciplines of international relations, European law, and regional security studies. The resolution of this question will be the single most consequential determinant of the regional order that emerges from the current conflict, and the quality of the intellectual analysis brought to bear on it will matter for the quality of the policy decisions ultimately made.

A Final Tocquevillian Reflection

Were Alexis de Tocqueville alive to observe the transformation of Central and Eastern Europe in the aftermath of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, one suspects he would recognize in it the confirmation of insights he developed nearly two centuries ago. He would recognize the geopolitical "tyranny of the majority"—the assertion of imperial will over the sovereign choices

of smaller nations—and he would recognize the democratic resilience that has met it: the extraordinary mobilization of civil society, the vitality of local and national institutions, and the demonstrated capacity of citizens to sacrifice comfort and security in defense of values they regard as non-negotiable.

He might also recognize something more hopeful—the possibility that democratic societies, when confronted with an existential challenge to their values and institutions, discover reserves of civic energy and collective commitment that are invisible in more comfortable times. The citizens of Poland who opened their homes to Ukrainian refugees, the volunteers who organized supply convoys under fire, the soldiers who defended Kyiv against overwhelming odds in the first days of the invasion, and the diplomats who built the coalitions that sustained Ukraine’s resistance—all of these are expressions of what Tocqueville most admired in democratic life: the capacity of free people to act together in defense of the values that make their freedom possible.

The transformation of Central and Eastern Europe is not complete. The regional order that emerges from the current conflict remains to be determined by decisions not yet made, by battles not yet fought, and by negotiations not yet concluded. But the direction of the transformation—toward a more assertive, more cohesive, and more strategically self-aware region committed to the defense of sovereignty and democratic governance against authoritarian aggression—is clear. Central and Eastern Europe has moved, irreversibly, from the periphery to the center of European strategic life, and the principles it is defending in the process are principles that Tocqueville would have recognized, and endorsed, without hesitation.

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